

# The Age After War - World Manual

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*A World Reference Document  
February 2026*



## THE AGE AFTER WAR

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### A World Manual for Players and Game Masters

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This document covers the world of the Age After War as it exists in Year 847 -- the present day of MMOLite. A companion document covers the Tavern Quest setting at Year 500. Both games share one world. The 347 years between them are the story of how eight races went from occupied subjects to reluctant partners.

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## CHAPTER 1: THE WORLD

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### 1.1 Introduction

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Eight hundred and forty-seven years ago, a weapon called Heaven's Atlas detonated over the elven homeland of Calidar and ended the Last World War in a single afternoon. The forests vitrified. The rivers boiled. The stone melted to glass. Somewhere between eighty and ninety percent of the elven population died before the sun set. The Holy Dominion, which had built and deployed the weapon, declared victory and began writing the history of a war they had won.

The empire that emerged from that victory banned magic. Not specific spells, not specific schools -- all of it. The Luminary Inquest was founded in Year 1 to enforce the ban, with execution authority and no appeal process. Seven other races survived the war in various states of damage and demoralization. The Dominion's Doctrine of the Chosen declared that humans were the rightful administrators of all other peoples. The elves, who survived only because they were useful as bureaucrats, began processing the paperwork that made everyone else's life legible -- and therefore controllable -- to the empire. The orcs, whose Khan had been the most effective military commander in recorded history, found themselves leaderless within a decade of the war's end. The goblins, who had no territory to lose, found themselves classified as a pest control problem.

For five centuries, this arrangement held. It did not hold well, and it did not hold peacefully -- there were suppressions, purges, resistance movements, and classified atrocities. But it held. Then a wound in the ground near the imperial capital, first noted in Year 75 as "a gap that goes further than it should," began to grow. By Year 500, the wound had a name: the Rift. By Year 600, the Adventure Guild had been founded to contain it. By Year 847 -- the present day -- the Rift is the only political problem large enough to make eight racial governments sit in the same room and sign the same document.

That document is the Second Compact. The eight signatories are the Holy Dominion, the elven Administration, the Free Holds of Stone, the orcish clan confederation, the Gnomish Collective, the goblin Resistance, the lizardfolk sects, and the cat folk diaspora. None of them trust each other. Most of them have specific historical grievances with at least two others on the list. The Compact works not because the parties like each other but because the Rift does not care who they are. The Adventure Guild -- the Compact's operational arm -- maintains ten anchor towns across the continent and a rank system that gives every member, regardless of race, the same institutional standing. It is the only structure in the world where that is true.

Two games are set in this world. Tavern Quest takes place in Year 500, when the Rift is classified and the empire is at the height of its confidence. MMOLite takes place in Year 847, after the Second Compact has been signed and the Rift has become the continent's defining crisis. The 347 years between those two settings are the story of how the world changed -- how six races that would not cooperate in Year 500 signed a binding compact in Year 625, how the Adventure Guild grew from a Veiled Hand shadow operation into a public institution with a charter, and how the wound in the ground went from classified geological note to a daily-seeded infinite dungeon that any registered Guild member can enter. That story is documented in the timeline at the end of this chapter. Players interested in the political roots of the current world will find Tavern Quest's setting indispensable context. Players who want to work in the world as it currently exists need only this manual.

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### 1.2 Geography

## The Main Continent

The continent is approximately 10,000 kilometers east to west and 12,500 kilometers north to south. No single political entity controls more than a quarter of its landmass. The Holy Dominion's imperial claims cover more territory on paper than any other power, but the empire's actual administrative reach ends well before its declared borders. Everything beyond the fortified road networks, the cathedral cities, and the documented farmland is, in practical terms, contested or uncontrolled.

The game world uses a chunk-based coordinate system. Chunks are 512 pixels wide, with one chunk representing approximately 5 kilometers at ground scale. The reference coordinate origin is at the Holy Dominion starter town, positioned at ref coordinates (35, 42). All other locations are described relative to this origin. Coordinates increase east and south; they decrease west and north. A player traveling from the starter town to Mechspire on the eastern islands covers approximately 57 ref units east -- roughly 285 kilometers as a straight-line distance, considerably more by any actual route.

## Named Regions

### The Holy Dominion.

The central plains of the continent. Temperate farmland, fortified roads, and cathedral cities arranged around the Dominion's administrative and theological infrastructure. The empire's largest population center -- approximately 1.5 million humans -- occupies this territory, with the imperial capital Solara at the political and religious center. The Luminary Inquest operates out of the Cathedral District, where the Rift's surface access point is located. The empire has not publicly acknowledged this proximity.

### The Elven South.

Dense forest southeast of the Dominion heartlands. The elven Administration, integrated into imperial bureaucratic structures since Year 1, runs its records offices and archival holdings from the canopy cities here. Towering trees older than the Last World War, ley-line intersections that the magic ban does not fully suppress, and sealed archives containing everything the elves documented about Calidar before Year 0. Sylvaris is the largest city. The archives below it contain the original copies of Seren Vaelas's classified Rift documentation from Year 250, which the Inquest believes it suppressed and which the elves filed correctly under seventeen cross-references.

### The Dwarven Mountains.

Alpine peaks running across the north-central continent. The Free Holds of Stone are entirely underground -- what the surface shows is rock face, sealed cave entrances, and the specific trade contact points where dwarves emerge on their own schedule to conduct commerce. The empire has been attempting to establish a formal military presence at the mountain approach for twenty years. The dwarves have not responded. Ironhold is the largest hold with surface-adjacent infrastructure; the deeper holds have not had an outsider inside them in living human memory.

### The Orcish Steppes.

Rolling grassland covering most of the western continent. The orcish clan confederation moves seasonally, with the larger encampments forming and dissolving based on grazing cycles and clan assembly schedules. Kragmor is the largest semi-permanent settlement -- what the empire's intelligence reports call a "compliant seasonal settlement" and what everyone who has visited calls a war camp. Thousands of orcs alive today personally served under the Great

Khan. They are patient in the specific way that people are patient when they have decided they can wait.

#### The Gnomish Isles.

Temperate islands far to the east, past the Silver Seas. The Gnomish Collective's industrial capital Mechspire is inland; Clockwork Harbor is the port city through which almost all mainland contact passes. Access requires permits that are almost always denied. The mainland liaison station at Windtrap processes permit applications and sends most of them back. The Collective has assessed the Holy Dominion as a terminal failure state since Year 120 and has been operating on that assessment, quietly, ever since.

#### Shadowfen.

A dense swamp in the southwest, classified by the empire as "uninhabitable exclusion zone." This classification is the official position and the Dominion knows it is inaccurate. Thousands of people live in the Shadow Fen Commune -- refugees, unsanctioned mages, documentation-less drifters, anyone who cannot exist under imperial paperwork. The commune is protected by the Veil, a field of concentrated refugee magic reinforced by infernal pacts. Imperial cartographers draw the swamp as impassable. The infernal pacts are real; the empire is aware of them; the empire prefers the commune to remain classified as swamp because acknowledging it requires acknowledging what the Veil's infernal sponsors imply. Murkmire is the commune's largest settlement, built on stilts above standing water.

#### The Wastes of Calidar.

South of the Elven South, extending deep into the southern continent. This is what Heaven's Atlas left behind. The forests are glass -- actual vitrified silica, sharp enough to cut through boot leather. The rivers are dry channels of fused stone where water once ran and boiled instantly. The interior is not merely inhospitable; it is the most comprehensively lethal terrain on the continent. No shelter exists, no water table is accessible, no life larger than certain extremophile fungi has been documented past the border zone. Every elf alive carries Calidar in cultural memory. The Ancient Ones -- the ten-thousand-year elves who are not playable characters -- speak of it in the present tense. Return is forbidden by imperial decree. The border draws scavengers attracted to residual magical discharge, which is the only reason the edge of the Wastes sees any human traffic at all.

#### The Great Endless Desert.

Central-south interior. Ancient sand, buried cities, and the surface evidence of the lizardfolk's five-thousand-year presence on this continent. The Hidden River Empire -- the lizardfolk civilization that migrated from the Subterranean Seas to the desert surface in pre-history -- maintains its primary underground networks here. The surface ruins that imperial cartographers record as pre-war astronomical instruments are correct: the Coldwatch observatory dates to before any other race arrived on this continent. The observatory below the ruins is still operational.

#### The Scorched Sands.

Western volcanic desert, distinct from the Wastes of Calidar. This is naturally hostile terrain: obsidian flows, active lava tubes, mineral deposits that attract mining operations every few decades until the heat drives them out. Some orcish clans use the fringes for coming-of-age trials. The goblin tunnel network at Redcap Junction runs under the imperial checkpoint that has been standing directly above it for sixty years.

#### The Frostbound Reach.

Far north tundra. Extreme cold, minimal infrastructure, very few settlements. The gnomish survey network extends here with a northern observation station that watches the continent from above the desert's northern edge. Primarily significant as the outer limit of mapped territory.

#### The Great Western Isle.

A large island approximately 30,000 square kilometers in area, positioned far to the west. Largely unmapped in current Guild records. Historical records reference it in connection with pre-war trade routes but contain no reliable post-war documentation.

### The Ashen Archipelago.

A volcanic island chain formed, at least partially, by the catastrophic volcanic event of Year minus-600 that reshaped the western ocean region. Earliest goblin diaspora patterns trace back to displaced populations from this area. Current status: sparsely inhabited, volcanically active.

### The Silver Seas and the Shimmering Sea.

The eastern waters between the main continent and the Gnomish Isles. Navigation is complicated by unpredictable currents and the Collective's patrol vessels, which enforce the permit system at sea as rigorously as Clockwork Harbor does on land.

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## 1.3 The Imperial Documentation System

Every person living within the Holy Dominion's administered territories carries papers. This is not a suggestion. A person without papers is, in legal terms, a person who does not exist -- which in practice means they can be detained, held indefinitely, or removed without any process whatsoever, because no process exists for a non-person. The system has operated this way since Year 5, when the Dominion's administrative council concluded that the magic ban required an enforcement mechanism that could track lineage, identify concealed magic users, and flag cross-racial cooperation that might constitute conspiracy. The documentation system is that mechanism. It was never intended as a public safety measure and has never functioned as one.

Every person's papers specify: identity (name, race, physical description), legal status (citizen, subject, restricted, provisional), magical lineage (three generations back, annotated for any documented magical ability), travel history (city of origin, current registered residence, any travel permits issued and their status), economic activity (registered employer, trade guild membership, property holdings, outstanding debts to imperial entities), and religious standing (registered faith, Helios observance status, any documented attendance at unsanctioned religious gatherings). Papers must be presented at city gates, bridge crossings, and random inspections conducted by Luminary Inquest officers or local garrison commanders. Officers have the authority to confiscate papers pending review. A person whose papers are confiscated pending review is in legal limbo with no defined timeline and no appeals process.

The system is administered primarily by elves. This is the central irony of its operation: the race whose homeland was destroyed by the empire, who survive under the empire's administration, are the people who run the paperwork that controls everyone else. The elves who administer the documentation system know every loophole, every vulnerability, every category classification that can be applied in more than one way. Certain files disappear. Certain travel permits are processed under the wrong category, which technically means they are valid for destinations they were not officially intended to cover. Certain individuals are recorded as having "returned to origin" when what actually happened is they were given a forty-eight-hour window and a route marked on paper in a specific way that experienced readers understand. The elves call this neither resistance nor collaboration. They call it precision.

The renewal cycle varies by race, which is a direct statement of institutional trust. Humans renew papers every five years -- a comfortable administrative rhythm that most humans never consciously notice. Elves renew every twenty years, a concession to their lifespan made in the Year 12 administrative reform. Orcs renew every three years, a direct product of Year 400 restrictions imposed after the orcish elder assembly was suppressed and four elders died in imperial custody. Goblins renew annually and are required to appear in person at a Luminary Inquest office, which is a meaningful burden given that goblins typically lack fixed residences and must travel to comply. Cat folk renew every six months. The six-month cycle was established in Year 312 as a temporary measure during a civil unrest period; the emergency has never been officially rescinded.

The Shadow Fen Commune's position is different from all others. Papers presented at the commune's border are burned. Not confiscated, not filed, not returned -- burned. The commune's founding document, ratified in Year 47 by the Shadow Fen Council, includes a single line on the subject: "Documentation issued by an occupying authority defines persons by the occupier's interest, not by any truth. We will not administer this definition." The infernal pacts that power the Veil protect the commune from the military enforcement that would otherwise follow from this position. The empire classifies Shadowfen as uninhabitable and processes no papers for it, which is the empire's way of declining to acknowledge that anyone lives there.

| Race                  | Relationship to Documentation                                                                                            |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Human                 | Renewal every 5 years. Regarded as administrative routine, not political instrument. Most humans have never had papers c |
| Elf                   | Renewal every 20 years. Administer the system; know every loophole; use them selectively and with plausible deniability. |
| Orc                   | Renewal every 3 years. Comply with visible resentment that most officers have learned to read as acceptable hostility wi |
| Beast Folk (Cat Folk) | Renewal every 6 months. Stopped for inspection far more often than any other race. Papers are confiscated at statistical |
| Goblin                | Annual renewal, in-person, at an Inquest office. Most goblins cannot comply with this requirement, which means most gobl |



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|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lizard Folk | Minimal compliance. Most lizardfolk activity occurs underground or in territories the empire maps as uninhabitable. Surf |
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|-------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Dwarf | Minimal compliance at designated surface trade posts. No imperial documentation authority has ever entered a hold. The d |
|-------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

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|-------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Gnome | Documentation compliance only at Clockwork Harbor. Gnomish Isles are outside imperial jurisdiction by treaty; mainland g |
|-------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

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|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Shadow Fen | Papers burned on entry. Empire classifies zone as uninhabitable; no documentation requirement is processed for a zone th |
|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

## CHAPTER 2: THE RACES

### 2.1 Human

"We are not the strongest race or the longest-lived or the most technically gifted. We are the ones who were standing when the smoke cleared. The Doctrine says this is divine providence. I have spent thirty years in the Inquest reviewing the files. I know what it actually was."

-- Auditor Cassia Vorn, Luminary Inquest (reassigned to the northern outpost, Year 831, circumstances not published)

#### Overview

Humans are the dominant political race in the known world by virtue of having deployed Heaven's Atlas in Year 0 and written the subsequent history. The Doctrine of the Chosen, the theological framework of the Holy Dominion, holds that Helios -- the sun deity at the center of human religion -- designated humanity as the rightful administrators of all other peoples. The Doctrine was formalized in Year 3 by the First Conclave of the Risen Light. The timing is notable: three years after the war ended, once it became clear the empire would face no military challenge to its victory. The Doctrine provided theological justification for what was already a political reality.

The Dominion's civilian population is largely unaware of the full mechanics of its own power. Humans cycle through institutional memory every two or three generations, which means the empire is perpetually administered by people who were not present for the decisions they are implementing. The Inquest officer conducting a documentation check at a city gate in Year 847 is enforcing a system established 847 years ago, updated in Year 400 in direct response to the orcish elder suppression he has never heard of, and staffed at ground level by elves who know more about its vulnerabilities than he does. This is not an exception to how the empire works. It is how the empire works.

Within the Dominion's own population, a significant moderate faction has existed since approximately Year 300 -- citizens, administrators, and clergy who believe the empire's enforcement scope has expanded beyond anything its founding documents justified. This faction does not have a name and is not organized. It exists as a recurring pattern in administrative decisions, documented dissent in internal correspondence, and specific Inquest officers who have a history of paperwork that disappears. The Adventure Guild has a disproportionate number of human members from this background.

#### Racial Traits

| Trait        | Value                            |
|--------------|----------------------------------|
| Lifespan     | 70-90 years                      |
| Stat Bonuses | +1 Presence, +1 Resolve          |
| Vision       | Normal (no special vision modes) |
| Languages    | Common                           |
| Racial Feat  | Dominion Authority               |

|                  |                                                                                                                          |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Feat Effect      | +15% XP gain in Holy Dominion zones; +20% market price advantage at imperial shops; access to Coercion and Deception soc |
| Card Weight      | Standard draw rates; no forced pool                                                                                      |
| Notable Weakness | No terrain speed bonus outside Dominion; reduced effectiveness on magic skill trees (Doctrine-instilled resistance to ma |

## Society and Government

The Holy Dominion is a theocratic empire administered by a hierarchy that runs from the High Conclave of the Risen Light at the top through regional governors, garrison commanders, and Luminary Inquest officers to the local clergy who function as the empire's ground-level administrative presence. The High Conclave controls theological interpretation, which controls legal interpretation, which controls every other function of government. There is no secular branch.

Electoral and representative structures exist at the municipal level -- city councils, guild assemblies, merchant boards -- but these bodies have no authority over Inquest operations, military deployment, or documentation policy. They manage local infrastructure and dispute resolution within parameters set by regional governors. The practical effect is that human citizens have genuine local political participation and no meaningful national political voice. Most humans have never noticed this gap because the empire functions well enough, for humans, that noticing the gap requires deliberate effort.

The Dominion's military has not fought an external war since Year 0. It has conducted domestic suppressions, border enforcement actions, and what the official record calls "pacification operations" against several racial groups. The distinction between military and police functions collapsed approximately two centuries into the post-war period and has never been reconstructed.

## Relations with Other Races

Humans within the Dominion generally experience other races through the documentation system -- as subjects requiring processing, as service providers, or as the exotic encountered on the road. The empire's educational system provides a version of racial history that is selective enough to be functionally false; the average educated Dominion citizen knows the Orc Khanate was a military threat that the war resolved and does not know about the Year 400 elder suppression, the goblin resistance network, or the infernal pacts underpinning the Shadowfen Commune's existence.

Outside the Dominion -- in Guild anchor towns, in Rift operations, in the territories where imperial authority is thin -- humans encounter other races on more level ground. Guild membership equalizes institutional standing by charter. Human characters outside their home territory discover that the deference they received from the documentation system does not follow them, which is either a shock or an education depending on the individual.

## Roleplaying Notes

- Human characters from the Dominion interior carry assumptions about institutional authority that other races do not share. The moment a human player assumes their Dominion status means something in a goblin warren or a dwarven hold, they have found their first meaningful cultural conflict.
  - The moderate internal faction is a legitimate backstory option: a human who left the Inquest, a clergy member who started reading the documents they were supposed to file, an administrator's child who asked the wrong question.
  - Human lifespan is the shortest of the eight playable races except cat folk and goblin. In conversations with elves, orcs, or lizardfolk, this is not abstract. An ancient elf NPC is speaking to a creature whose entire civilization exists within a portion of her living memory.
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## 2.2 Elf

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"You ask how I keep the records straight after eight hundred years. The same way I kept them straight after four hundred. The same way I will keep them straight after twelve hundred, if the Rift permits it. Precision is not a talent. It is what you do when you have enough time to notice every error you have ever made."

-- Archivist Thessiel of Sylvaris, responding to a new Guild inductee's question, Year 832

### Overview

The elves of the Age After War are defined by two facts that exist in permanent tension: they are the most administratively capable race on the continent, and the state they administer destroyed their homeland. The surviving elves of Calidar were resettled in planned districts in the early post-war decades, permitted to maintain their archival traditions because the empire needed record-keepers, and gradually integrated into the Dominion's administrative apparatus as the most efficient solution to an enormous bureaucratic problem. The elven integration is the empire's most successful administrative achievement and its most morally incoherent one.

Playable elves live between 500 and 800 years. This lifespan is long enough to remember Calidar through personal testimony -- an 800-year elf born in Year 47 was alive when the resettlement began, when the Veil's first infernal pacts were negotiated, when the first Rift cartographers disappeared. A 500-year elf born in Year 347 grew up hearing those events from adults who were there. The living memory problem runs in both directions: elves know more about the empire's actual history than the empire's human administrators do, because elves were present for more of it and keep better records. This is leverage of a specific kind -- not military, not political, but informational.

The Ancient Ones are a separate population. Ten-thousand-year elves who survived Calidar, survived the resettlement, and are still alive in Year 847 are not playable characters. They exist in the world as NPCs of particular weight: figures who speak about pre-war Calidar with the familiarity of yesterday, who remember the civilization that died in the First Confluence, who know things about the Rift's nature that predate every other race's surface presence. They do not hold imperial positions. The empire made one attempt to employ an Ancient One in Year 23, which the Ancient One declined in a single sentence, and the empire did not repeat the attempt.

### Racial Traits

| Trait | Value |
|-------|-------|
|-------|-------|

|                |                                                                                 |
|----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lifespan       | 500-800 years (playable); 10,000+ years (Ancient Ones, NPC tier)                |
| Stat Bonuses   | +1 Acumen, +1 Finesse                                                           |
| Stat Penalties | -2 Vigor, -1 Might (physically frail; elves are not built for sustained combat) |

|             |                                                                                                                         |
|-------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Vision      | Normal                                                                                                                  |
| Languages   | Elvish, Common                                                                                                          |
| Racial Feat | Millennial Memory                                                                                                       |
| Feat Effect | +50% magic skill XP gain; +30% bonus unlocks on magic skill trees; access to elven archive knowledge checks; +15% bonus |

|                  |                                                                                                                          |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Card Draw Weight | 40% chance per card draw is forced to the magic-tagged card pool                                                         |
| Notable Weakness | -15% melee combat effectiveness; -10% maximum HP (frail constitution); magic-tagged pool weighting means fewer cards fro |

## Society and Government

The elven Administration is not a government in the traditional sense -- it is the bureaucratic caste that the post-war empire created and which has become, over 847 years, as close to a racial institution as surviving elves have. The Administration's formal structure mirrors the Dominion's: regional archivists, document review boards, and records offices that process imperial paperwork. Its informal structure is something else entirely.

Elvish social organization runs on information. Who knows what, who has access to which records, which cross-references survive in sealed archives that imperial administrators have never looked at closely enough -- these are the currencies of internal elven politics. Senior archivists are powerful not because of their rank but because of what they have filed where. An elf who has spent four centuries in a records office knows where the irregularities are, knows which files have been altered, and knows which alterations were made by whom. The Administration does not have a unified political agenda. It has individuals with specific knowledge, acting on specific opportunities, with plausible deniability maintained through meticulous paperwork.

The cultural wound of Calidar runs beneath all of this. Elves do not speak about Calidar casually in human company. Among themselves, in their own language, in the archival subculture of the Administration, Calidar is present in everything: in the specific taxonomy of loss that Elvish has for things destroyed rather than merely gone, in the way elves who never saw it still treat return to it as a matter of when rather than if, in the sealed sections of the archive that contain full documentation of the homeland that the empire burned and then forbade.

## Relations with Other Races

The elves' relationship with other races is shaped almost entirely by their position as the empire's administrative instrument. Every orc who has had a travel permit delayed knows it was processed through an elven office. Every goblin who has had papers confiscated knows the file was created by elven hands. The fact that some of those elves are

working against the system as systematically as they can within it does not change the first impression, which is the one most people carry.

Within the Adventure Guild, elves are valued for their archival skills and their lifespan -- an elven Guild member can build institutional memory across centuries in a way no human member can. Guild relations between elves and other races tend to be functional and careful. The deepest conflicts are with goblins, who have the most historical reason for distrust, and who know, specifically, that the paperwork that classified their communities as criminal was processed through elven offices. The deepest trust is with lizardfolk, who share an interest in long-term documentation and who have, for five millennia, been keeping records of things no one else thought to write down.

### Roleplaying Notes

- Playing an elf means playing inside the empire's most uncomfortable irony. There is no clean position here -- elves survived by making themselves useful to the empire that destroyed them, and many elves have spent centuries asking themselves what that means.
  - The archive connection is a genuine in-game advantage. Elven characters can access cross-references, sealed records, and historical documentation that other races cannot reach through normal channels.
  - The frailty penalties are real in combat. Elves built for magic-based playstyles will rarely notice; elves who try to specialize in melee will feel the stat gap continuously.
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## 2.3 Orc

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"The Khan unified forty-seven clans in twelve years. The empire suppressed the elder assembly in Year 400 because six clans met in one place and they knew what that meant. Draw your own conclusions about who they are afraid of."

-- Clan Elder Borrath, speaking at the Year 847 Rift Compact assembly, attributed

### Overview

The orcs have not had a unified government since the Great Khan died in Year minus-45, and the empire has worked deliberately to ensure that remains true. The Khanate, at its height, was the most effective military organization in recorded history -- forty-seven clans unified under a single legal code, operating with a command structure that the empire's military historians have studied in classified documents for eight centuries. The Khan died during the war's southern campaign. The cause is disputed. The succession clause in his legal code was unfinished at the time of his death, which meant no new Khan could be legitimately named, which meant the Khanate fractured into grieving clan confederations within a decade.

The orcs' defining characteristic, from the outside, is patience. Thousands of orcs alive in Year 847 personally served under the Great Khan. They remember the Khanate's legal code well enough to debate its finer points from memory. The Great Khan died 847 years ago, and for an orc with a 300-to-500-year lifespan, that is approximately two lifetimes -- not the remote historical past that it is for a human. The orcish clans have not reunified because every attempt at reunion since Year 0 has been met with immediate imperial military response. The suppression of Year 400, when four elders died in imperial custody, is not a historical footnote in the steppes; it is something specific people's grandparents witnessed.

What the orcs are building, in the interim, is what the empire cannot see: a philosophical and legal tradition that treats the Khan's unfinished succession clause as a technical problem awaiting a technical solution. Several scholars within the clan confederation have been working on that problem for centuries, in private, without producing anything the empire has found. Whether this is patience or preparation depends on who you ask.

### Racial Traits

| Trait            | Value                                                                                                                    |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lifespan         | 300-500 years                                                                                                            |
| Stat Bonuses     | +1 Might, +1 Vigor                                                                                                       |
| Stat Penalties   | -1 Acumen                                                                                                                |
| Vision           | Normal                                                                                                                   |
| Languages        | Orcish, Common                                                                                                           |
| Racial Feat      | Khanate Vitality                                                                                                         |
| Feat Effect      | +25% bonus to melee and archery skill XP; +25% maximum HP; +2 HP regeneration per second; clan memory social bonuses wit |
| Card Weight      | Standard draw rates; no forced pool                                                                                      |
| Notable Weakness | Reduced magic skill effectiveness; enhanced documentation requirements in imperial zones (travel permits require pre-aut |

### Society and Government

The orcish confederation has no central government. The clans -- forty-seven at the Khanate's height, thirty-nine currently recognized under confederation law -- govern themselves internally under their own chieftain structures and interact with other clans through a system of assemblies and councils that the Khan's legal code established as the mechanism for collective decision-making. The assemblies require quorum rules that the empire's military response to the Year 400 gathering disrupted permanently; holding a legal assembly now requires a specific set of conditions that has been met once in 847 years.

The steppes society that emerged from this structure is primarily oral in culture -- the Khan's legal code exists in written form but survives primarily as memorized recitation, which the empire has found frustratingly impossible to suppress. Tent cities form and dissolve on seasonal patterns that double as military logistics, a fact the empire's analysts noted in Year 612 and have been unable to change. Horse culture is central to orcish military capacity: the steppes cavalry tradition is unbroken from the Khanate period, and every generation of clan warriors is trained to the same standard that the Khan's generals codified. The empire has never found a satisfactory way to address this in open documentation, so it does not appear in open documentation.

### Relations with Other Races

The orcs' relationship with the Holy Dominion is the defining relationship of orcish political life. Everything else is secondary to the fact that the empire suppressed the confederation, killed elders in custody, and maintains ongoing surveillance and travel restrictions on orcish movement. The clan chieftains who engage with Guild operations do so because the Guild's charter gives them institutional standing the Dominion will not, not because they have resolved their grievances with the empire.

Relations with dwarves are historically respectful -- both cultures value practical achievement over formal authority, and the dwarven position of never-conquered resonates with orcish political aspirations. Relations with goblins are complicated by the same history: the goblin resistance's tactics and the orcish confederation's patient legal strategy are not in conflict, but they are not in coordination either, and both cultures have enough internal disagreement about the right approach that alliance has never been formalized.

### Roleplaying Notes

- Playing an orc in imperial territory means playing under the specific weight of enhanced documentation requirements. Pre-authorization for inter-regional travel is not flavor text. It creates genuine play friction in zones where orcs are stopped more frequently and travel permits are processed slowly.
- The Khan's living memory is present in orcish NPC dialogue throughout the steppes. An orc player character choosing to engage with that history will find it more specific and more recent than any other race's historical connections.
- The combat bonuses are the strongest melee-focused package in the game. Orc characters who build into the Khanate Vitality tree will have significant advantages in physical combat and long-session resource harvesting.

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## 2.4 Dwarf

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"The surface people keep asking how we govern ourselves without a king. We keep explaining that we do not need a king because we are not afraid of each other. They keep asking the question, which tells you something about them."

-- Hold Steward Brekka Ironseam, during a Guild negotiation, Year 803

### Overview

The dwarves of the Free Holds of Stone have the simplest relationship with imperial authority of any race in the confederation: they do not have one. The holds are underground, the empire has no presence inside them, and the dwarves' position -- that documentation requirements apply to persons traveling in imperial territory, and holds are not imperial territory -- has never been tested militarily because the empire's military planners have never completed a satisfactory assessment of what assaulting the mountain holds would cost. The assessment has been requested three times by different regional governors. The third request came back with a two-word summary that the archives classify as "not suitable for general distribution."

Dwarven society is organized around labor and skill, not bloodline or divine authority. The Free Holds of Stone is an anarcho-syndicalist federation -- each hold is governed by an assembly of its workers, organized by trade, with decisions made by direct vote among the members of the relevant guild. There is no central authority beyond the



inter-hold assembly, which convenes annually at a location that rotates between holds and which makes decisions by unanimous consensus. Unanimity is slow. The dwarves regard this as a feature. A decision that requires unanimous agreement from thirty-nine hold assemblies is a decision that will be implemented with thirty-nine holds behind it.

The Deep Schism of Year minus-2000 is the defining internal divide of dwarven history: some dwarves refused to surface, descended into the hollow earth, and sealed the passages behind them. Whether those dwarves still exist, and in what form, is a subject that above-ground dwarven culture does not discuss with non-dwarves and discusses with evident unease among themselves. Guild dungeon documentation has encountered passage features consistent with dwarven construction in Rift floors that should not contain them. No Guild query to Ironhold on this subject has received a response.

## Racial Traits

| Trait          | Value                                                                                                                    |
|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lifespan       | 300-500 years                                                                                                            |
| Stat Bonuses   | +1 Vigor, +1 Ingenuity                                                                                                   |
| Stat Penalties | -1 Finesse                                                                                                               |
| Vision         | Darkvision (no penalty in low-light or underground environments)                                                         |
| Languages      | Dwarvish, Common                                                                                                         |
| Racial Feat    | Stone-Born Artisan                                                                                                       |
| Feat Effect    | +25% mining and crafting skill XP; +15% bonus on gem-working and jewelry; passive Stone Skin (+10 armor rating); minor t |

|                  |                                                                                                                          |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Card Weight      | Standard draw rates; no forced pool                                                                                      |
| Notable Weakness | Reduced effectiveness in water environments; surface travel in imperial zones requires documentation at designated trade |

## Society and Government

Each hold is self-governing. The guild assembly format means every major decision in a hold is a collective one -- the master smith has authority over smithing matters, the miners' assembly votes on extraction plans, the engineering guild approves construction. No individual holds authority across guild lines. The position of Hold Steward is administrative rather than executive: a Steward facilitates the assembly process, maintains records, and represents the hold in inter-hold communications. Stewards do not give orders.

The inter-hold assembly meets annually and operates by consensus. This means dwarven external policy changes slowly and with broad buy-in when it changes. The decision to allow Guild anchor town presence at Ironhold took eleven years of assembly deliberation. The decision to permit non-dwarven access to a single specific tunnel level for Guild research purposes took twenty-three years. The dwarves regard this pacing as reasonable. The Guild, which operates

on continental emergency timescales, has learned to submit proposals to the assembly well in advance and to wait.

Economic life in the holds is collectively organized. Mining output belongs to the hold's commons; individual dwarves receive labor shares based on hours worked and skill level, calibrated by the relevant guild assembly. Property within holds is leasehold rather than freehold -- individual dwarves hold use rights, not ownership. Surface trade is conducted at specific contact points on schedules the holds set unilaterally. The empire's attempts to establish price controls on dwarven exports have produced no result except that some holds stopped attending certain market days.

## Relations with Other Races

Dwarves hold no systematic negative attitudes toward other races. This is not political neutrality -- the dwarves have specific views about imperial authority that they will express directly if asked, and they have expressed them directly in Guild assembly sessions with sufficient clarity that the Dominion's Guild observer has filed three formal protests in eight years. But dwarven culture does not organize around racial hierarchy, which means individual dwarves in the world tend to interact with other races on the basis of what those races actually do rather than what category they belong to.

The closest inter-racial relationship in dwarven history is with the gnomes, whose collectivist economic organization the dwarves consider roughly correct even if the gnomish implementation prioritizes innovation in a way that dwarven culture finds slightly chaotic. The most difficult relationship is with the Holy Dominion's administrative structure, which dwarves in surface contact posts encounter as an entity that cannot accept the simple statement that the holds are not imperial territory and therefore the documentation requirements do not apply.

## Roleplaying Notes

- Dwarven characters entering imperial territory for the first time encounter the documentation system from the position of minimal compliance: technically legal, minimally cooperative, impossible to intimidate. The documentation check scene plays differently with a dwarf than with almost any other race.
- The darkvision and tremor sense are practically significant in dungeon play. Dwarven characters have genuine perceptual advantages underground that translate to combat positioning and exploration.
- The Stone-Born Artisan feat creates one of the strongest crafting specializations in the game. A dwarf who invests in mining and crafting skill trees will produce better material outputs than any equivalent non-dwarf.

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## 2.5 Gnome

---

"The Phase One assessment was completed in Year 120. The Phase One conclusion was that the Dominion would reach critical failure conditions within five centuries, barring significant internal reform. We are now 727 years past Year 120. The assessment has not required revision."

-- Production Council Communique 7, released Year 847, translated from Gnomish

## Overview

The Gnomish Collective is the most deliberately isolationist political entity in the known world, and it has been since Year 120 when the Collective's production councils conducted their first formal assessment of the Holy Dominion and concluded it was a terminal failure state. The councils did not publicize this assessment. They updated their operational posture, began a controlled withdrawal from mainland contact, and have been acting on that withdrawal plan quietly ever since. What remains of the Collective's mainland presence -- Windtrap Station, Clockwork Harbor's carefully managed trade function -- is exactly as much contact as serves the Collective's intelligence requirements. Not more.

Gnomish technology operates at a level that makes the Dominion's infrastructure look pre-industrial. The Collective solved the labor problem several centuries ago through automaton construction, which freed gnomish workers from repetitive industrial tasks and created a feedback loop of engineering advancement. Mechspire runs on clockwork systems that gnomish engineers rebuild and upgrade on a continuous schedule; Clockwork Harbor's automated loading equipment processes more cargo per hour than three comparable human ports combined. The Collective does not share this technology, not because they are secretive about having it, but because the production councils assessed in Year 340 that sharing it would destabilize the continental economy in ways that would benefit the Dominion more than anyone else. They did not share it.

Survey Station 3, established in Year 480 at the northern edge of the Frostbound Reach, has one specific operational mission: detect Heaven's Atlas-class energetic signatures. The gnomes are watching for the weapon that destroyed Calidar, which they believe exists somewhere in a state of either hidden storage or deliberate concealment. They have not detected it. This has not reassured the councils. The instrument that cannot detect Heaven's Atlas is either accurate (the weapon is destroyed or degraded) or inadequate (the weapon is shielded). The councils have been building increasingly sensitive instruments for 367 years. The weapon has not appeared. Phase Three of the contingency plan was updated at an internal council session within the last decade. Three council members who would have opposed its original provisions were reassigned before the vote.

## Racial Traits

| Trait          | Value                                                                                                                    |
|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lifespan       | 200-350 years                                                                                                            |
| Stat Bonuses   | +1 Ingenuity, +1 Acumen                                                                                                  |
| Stat Penalties | -1 Might                                                                                                                 |
| Vision         | Normal                                                                                                                   |
| Languages      | Gnomish, Common                                                                                                          |
| Racial Feat    | Tinker Savant                                                                                                            |
| Feat Effect    | +50% cogworking skill XP; +25% engineering and automaton-related crafting bonuses; access to Gnomish-exclusive blueprint |

|                  |                                                                                                                        |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Card Draw Weight | Standard rates; no forced pool                                                                                         |
| Notable Weakness | Physical combat penalties (-1 Might is significant at low levels); documentation requirements at Clockwork Harbor only |
|                  | -                                                                                                                      |

## Society and Government

The Collective is governed by production councils organized by industry sector. The council structure covers every major production category: agriculture, manufacturing, engineering, survey and intelligence, external affairs, and the defense council whose deliberations are not shared with non-council members. Each sector council operates by majority vote. The inter-council body that makes decisions across sectors operates by supermajority. No single gnome has executive authority over any other gnome's work domain.

Individual gnomes within the Collective hold their tools, their intellectual work, and their personal property. Productive infrastructure -- the factories, the automaton workshops, the harbor equipment, the survey network -- belongs to the Collective commons. Income from collective enterprise is distributed through a labor credit system that assigns value to work time and skill level as assessed by the relevant sector council. This system has been operational since before Year 0 and has been adjusted eleven times; the most recent adjustment was in Year 800, in response to automaton labor displacing certain categories of gnomish work in ways the original system had not accounted for.

Gnomish external affairs are managed by the trade representative assigned to Clockwork Harbor, who holds the only official contact role with non-gnomish governments that the Collective recognizes. The current trade representative is Kelva, who has held the position for forty years and has access to more gnomish internal information than any non-gnome alive -- which still does not include the contents of Phase Three.

### Relations with Other Races

The Collective's official relationship with all other races is managed through trade. The trade relationship is real and actively maintained: gnomish precision instruments, clockwork components, and manufactured goods reach the continent through Clockwork Harbor in exchange for raw materials the islands do not produce. The relationship is commercial, not political. The gnomes will not sign onto political arrangements that commit Collective resources to continental problems; the Second Compact required significant internal debate and passed by a narrow margin, with multiple provisions specifically limiting what gnomish participation obligates the Collective to provide.

Within Guild operations, gnomish members are consistently assigned to technical and documentation roles that their Tinker Savant capabilities make them naturally suited for. Their relationships with individual members of other races are functional and occasionally warm; the Collective's institutional isolation does not transfer to individual gnomish personality. The cultural difficulty is that gnomes from Mechspire arrive in the wider world with an accurate understanding of how much their government knows about continental affairs and how little of that knowledge they are allowed to share. This creates a specific dynamic: gnomish characters who know things they cannot say, about matters they genuinely care about, in conversations where the information would be directly useful.

### Roleplaying Notes

- Gnomish characters in mainland settings carry the Collective's intelligence advantage and the Collective's communication restrictions simultaneously. Playing a gnome is partly playing the tension between what your character knows and what they are institutionally permitted to share.
- The Tinker Savant feat creates the strongest crafting output for mechanical items, automated systems, and precision instruments. A gnome who invests in cogworking will outperform every other race in that specific tree.
- Gnomish players in the Rift have institutional reasons to document thoroughly -- the Collective wants Rift data. This creates a natural alignment between the gnomish racial identity and the adventure documentation culture the Guild promotes.

## 2.6 Goblin

"My grandmother taught me the names of the forty who died in Year 412. Her grandmother taught her the names of the sixty who died in Year 303. The names go back to Year 0. We have not had enough years to forget them. We will not forget them until we have had enough years to do something about them instead."

-- Krix, goblin oral tradition keeper, approximate age 45

### Overview

The goblin resistance has been an active guerrilla network for 500 years. It was not always called the resistance -- in the early post-war decades it was called the community, because that is what it was, before the Documentation Act of Year 12 classified goblin settlements as illegal encampments and their occupants as persons subject to removal on administrative grounds. The network that emerged from the subsequent decades of eviction, detention, and documentation confiscation is genuinely decentralized: cells of five to twenty, no central command, no permanent leadership, no headquarters. The empire calls it pest control. The goblins call it the only structure their circumstances permit.

Goblin lifespan is 30-to-60 years. This is the shortest lifespan of any of the eight races except humans, and it creates a specific survival problem: how does a resistance movement sustain itself across 500 years when its members live an average of 45 years? The answer is oral tradition maintained with the rigor of legal documentation. Goblin oral tradition keepers -- individuals specifically trained in memorization and transmission -- carry the names of the dead, the specifics of every significant operation, and the locations of active tunnel networks in human memory because writing is dangerous and the empire burns books. The tradition has not broken in 500 years. Every generation teaches the names of what was taken and everything attached to those names, including the names of who took it.

BoneTrap, the goblin anchor town, is a warren in the steppes borderlands that outsiders are usually robbed upon entering. This is not a security failure. The entrance protocol is a first-pass evaluation of whether visitors are worth speaking to further. Visitors who respond to the robbery by attempting to leave receive their possessions back and a polite suggestion that they try Kragmor. Visitors who respond by demonstrating they understand the situation are eventually introduced to someone with actual authority, which takes longer and involves more discomfort, which is the point.

### Racial Traits

| Trait          | Value                                                                        |
|----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lifespan       | 30-60 years                                                                  |
| Stat Bonuses   | +1 Finesse, +1 Resolve                                                       |
| Stat Penalties | -1 Might                                                                     |
| Vision         | Darkvision (no penalty in low-light environments; native tunnel orientation) |
| Languages      | Goblin, Common                                                               |
| Racial Feat    | Guerrilla Instinct                                                           |

|                  |                                                                                                                          |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Feat Effect      | +30% stealth skill XP; +20% bonus to stealth attack, thievery, lockpicking, and archery skills; +30% movement speed in a |
| Card Draw Weight | 35% chance per card draw is forced to the stealth-tagged card pool                                                       |
| Notable Weakness | Annual documentation renewal required in imperial zones; goblins without current papers are technically in violation, wh |

## Society and Government

The resistance has no government. It has cells and a tradition. Each cell operates independently with its own leadership, its own operational priorities, and its own local knowledge. Cells share information through a courier network that uses landmarks, dead drops, and coded oral messages rather than written correspondence. The network is robust against infiltration because no cell member has access to more than their immediate cell's information and one contact outside it.

The oral tradition keepers are not a governing body but they are an authority: keepers from different cells know the same core tradition because they were all trained from the same source material, which means they can authenticate each other and coordinate on matters of historical record. When cells disagree about facts -- which happened during the Year 620 negotiations over the First Compact -- the keepers convene and the tradition resolves it. This is not a perfect system. It is a system designed to function when every other system is being actively destroyed.

Goblin cultural values center on specific practical skills: tunnel construction, trap placement, supply caching, information security, and the specific kind of patience that comes from knowing you are not going to win on your timeline but your children might win on theirs. The goblin aesthetic -- dark, cramped, efficient, frequently disguised as something else -- is functional rather than decorative. BoneTrap looks like a deteriorating ruin from the outside because that is what keeps imperial patrols from looking more closely.

## Relations with Other Races

The goblins have useful working relationships with the Shadow Fen Commune (shared refugee network, tunnel access under the swamp), with certain orcish clan factions (shared enemies, shared territory in the borderlands), and with elven administrative sympathizers who occasionally make files disappear. The relationship with the Holy Dominion is not hostile -- hostility implies the possibility of resolution. It is something more settled than that.

Within Guild operations, goblins tend toward roles that use their Guerrilla Instinct skills: dungeon scouting, trap detection, information gathering, and the specific set of social skills that involves knowing what people are not saying. Guild membership gives goblins institutional standing that no other structure provides, which is one of the reasons goblin Guild enrollment is disproportionately high relative to their population. The Guild's founding compact was signed in a

format specifically designed to accommodate goblin objections: the copy the goblins signed does not appear on the same document as the Dominion's copy, and both copies are equally binding.

### Roleplaying Notes

- A goblin player in imperial zones is playing under a specific mechanical pressure: documentation requirements that create genuine friction, elevated NPC suspicion, and the daily renewable tension of existing in a system that classifies your community as illegal by default.
  - The Guerrilla Instinct feat is the strongest stealth-and-rogue package in the game. A goblin who invests in thievery, lockpicking, and archery will outperform other races in those specific trees substantially.
  - The oral tradition is a role-playing resource. Goblin characters have access to historical knowledge that official records suppress -- the names of specific operations, the locations of tunnels, the specific circumstances of deaths that were classified as natural causes. This knowledge has genuine in-game utility.
- 

## 2.7 Lizard Folk

---

"You are asking me how old the Rift is. I will answer a different question: what is the oldest thing you know that is not the Rift? Because everything you just named, we were here before."

-- Sect Elder Vashari, declining to specify which sect, during the Year 847 Rift Compact session

### Overview

The lizardfolk are the longest-lived surface race on the continent, the oldest political presence on the continent, and the group with the most complete information about the Rift's actual nature. They say very little, and they are always specific when they say it. These two facts are related.

The lizardfolk's surface ancestors migrated from the Subterranean Seas approximately five thousand years ago. The Hidden River Empire -- the lizardfolk civilization that exists mostly underground, organized along the Great Endless Desert's subsurface river networks -- is older than every other political entity on the continent. The lizardfolk who are visible on the surface -- the fifteen thousand or so who interact with other races, maintain Guild presence, and manage inter-racial commerce -- are a small fraction of the total population, which is not known to anyone outside the lizardfolk sects. The empire's census lists 15,000. The lizardfolk have not corrected this figure.

Surface-visible lizardfolk are organized into knowledge sects: the Trade Routes Sect, the Astronomy Sect, the Burial Rites Sect, and several others that maintain less public profiles. Sects share information through private networks organized around the specific knowledge domain each sect manages. The Astronomy Sect founded the Veiled Hand in Year 1. The Trade Routes Sect manages the caravan network that maintains goblin and cat folk supply lines. The Burial Rites Sect documents the dead in a record that includes every significant death since the sect began keeping records, which they date to Year minus-4200. The Inquest has never accessed this archive. The archive knows about the Inquest.

## Racial Traits

| Trait                  | Value                                                                                                                      |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lifespan               | 600-800 years                                                                                                              |
| Stat Bonuses           | +1 Acumen, +1 Resolve, +1 Finesse                                                                                          |
| Stat Penalties         | -1 Presence (default lizardfolk affect reads as cold to most other races)                                                  |
| Vision                 | Thermal (detect heat signatures through walls and in complete darkness; cannot read text in darkness without light source) |
| Languages              | Draconic, Common                                                                                                           |
| Racial Feat            | Aquatic Heritage                                                                                                           |
| Feat Effect            | +15% fishing skill XP; swim and dive without movement penalty; permanent water breathing; access to underwater cave system |
| Card Draw Weight       | 25% chance per card draw is forced to the ritual-tagged card pool                                                          |
| Racial Skills (Locked) | Ritual Magic, Water Rituals, Blood Rituals -- accessible only to lizardfolk; untradeable to other races                    |
| Notable Weakness       | Social interactions with non-lizardfolk NPCs begin at a trust deficit (-1 Presence effects on initial interaction); there  |

## Society and Government

The lizardfolk sects are not a government. There is no lizardfolk state, no elected body, no administrative structure analogous to any other racial organization. The sects are knowledge-preservation institutions, each responsible for maintaining and transmitting the accumulated understanding in their domain. The Trade Routes Sect knows every caravan path across the desert, every water cache location, every safe shelter between surface points. The Astronomy Sect has celestial records going back four thousand years. The Burial Rites Sect has the dead. These are not metaphors. These are archives.

Sect membership is by invitation only and permanent. Lizardfolk are identified by the sect that trained them. There is no cross-sect authority; the sects cooperate when their interests align and operate independently when they do not. The Hidden River Empire that exists beneath the desert surface has its own governance structure that surface-visible lizardfolk reference obliquely and describe in detail to no one.

The Veiled Hand -- the anti-escalation assassination network founded in Year 1 -- was created by the Astronomy Sect after the sect's celestial record analysis at Year 0 produced the conclusion that the empire would repeat the Heaven's



Atlas deployment if not specifically deterred. The Veiled Hand's founding mandate is narrow: remove individuals whose plans, if enacted, would cause mass atrocity. It does not have a broader political program. It does not have ranks or central command. It has the Astronomy Sect's assessment capacity and the patience of a culture that measures time in millennia.

### Relations with Other Races

The lizardfolk's relationships with other races are functional and deliberately maintained at arm's length. The Trade Routes Sect's caravan network serves goblin resistance supply lines, cat folk diaspora commerce, and Guild logistics across the desert without explicit political alliance. The Astronomy Sect's information network reaches every part of the continent without the sect ever claiming credit for what it knows. The practical effect is that lizardfolk characters tend to know things, and the challenge of playing one is deciding what to share.

The deepest inter-racial relationship is with elves, specifically with elven archivists who have been keeping records in their own tradition for eight centuries. Both groups are in the business of preserving information that powerful entities would prefer destroyed. They have exchanged materials through Guild channels since Year 630. They do not advertise this relationship. The most fraught relationship is with the Holy Dominion, specifically with the Luminary Inquest, whose history the Burial Rites Sect documents in detail and whose continued existence the Astronomy Sect considers the single most significant ongoing risk factor for a Heaven's Atlas recurrence.

### Roleplaying Notes

- Playing a lizardfolk character means playing someone who knows more about the world's deep history than any other playable race. The challenge is that this knowledge is sect-specific, not universal -- a Trade Routes lizardfolk knows the continent's commercial networks in extraordinary depth, but may not know what the Astronomy Sect knows about the Rift.
- Thermal vision is a significant practical advantage in dungeon play. Seeing through walls and detecting heat signatures changes the information available to a lizardfolk character in every Rift floor.
- The ritual magic skill trees are powerful and race-locked. Lizardfolk players who invest in Ritual Magic, Water Rituals, and Blood Rituals access abilities that no other race can replicate and cannot trade away.

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## 2.8 Cat Folk (Beast Folk)

"The Salt Court has been meeting annually for at least two hundred years. The empire does not know it exists. I mention this because when people ask how the diaspora survives without a territory or a government, I want them to understand: we do not lack structure. We lack the kind of structure that needs to own land to function."

-- Trade Arbiter Mira of the Salt Court, Year 841

### Overview

The cat folk are the diaspora race. No territory, no government, no recognized legal standing in imperial courts. The

documentation system marks them and goblins as the highest-risk categories for what the empire's internal reports call "processing irregularities." They carry multiple copies of their papers because confiscation is routine. They renew every six months because the empire has never officially ended the Year 312 emergency declaration that established that cycle.

What the cat folk have instead of territory is mobility and pattern recognition. The diaspora moves through desert trade routes, gambling towns, and commercial hubs across the continent, conducting commerce and maintaining their own legal traditions through the Salt Court -- an annual gathering that has met for at least two centuries without imperial knowledge and has resolved every significant inter-community dispute in that time with a binding arbitration record. The Salt Court meets at Fortune's Rest, which the empire's maps describe as a desert gambling town. The maps are not wrong. They are incomplete.

Fortune's Rest is the closest thing the diaspora has to a fixed home, and it is fixed only in the sense that it is the place that various cat folk return to. The town is built on a desert oasis and runs on gambling, trade caravan commerce, and information brokerage. The information that passes through Fortune's Rest is valuable enough that the Veiled Hand has maintained a contact in the town since Year 340. Guild intelligence considers Fortune's Rest one of the best early-warning locations on the continent for political developments in the desert quadrant.

Cat folk lifespan is 60-80 years -- longer than goblins but shorter than humans, which means the diaspora's cultural continuity works differently from the goblin oral tradition. Cat folk use written records, maintained carefully and carried in formats designed to survive confiscation. Every cat folk community of more than twenty keeps a community record. The community records use a writing system that Imperial linguists have not decoded, partly because the cipher is changed on a schedule the communities coordinate at the Salt Court.

## Racial Traits

| Trait          | Value                                                                    |
|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lifespan       | 60-80 years                                                              |
| Stat Bonuses   | +1 Finesse, +1 Presence                                                  |
| Stat Penalties | -1 Vigor                                                                 |
| Vision         | Darkvision (complete darkness navigation; natural nocturnal orientation) |

|             |                                                                                                                          |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Languages   | Catfolk, Common                                                                                                          |
| Racial Feat | Pattern Recognition                                                                                                      |
| Feat Effect | +20% card draw luck (increased chance of rare-and-above outcomes); +15% general luck affecting random event outcomes; un |

|                  |                                                                                                            |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Card Draw Weight | 40% chance per card draw is forced to the luck-tagged card pool; +20% rarity bump chance on all card draws |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

|                  |                                                                                                                          |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Notable Weakness | Renewal every 6 months in imperial zones; elevated stop-and-inspect frequency in imperial territory; -1 Vigor creates HP |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

## Society and Government

The cat folk diaspora governs itself through the Salt Court. The Court meets annually, draws attendance from every active diaspora community on the continent, and has authority over inter-community disputes, trade agreements, and the maintenance of the cipher used in community records. It is not a legislature and does not create new law; its function is arbitration and coordination. The arbitration decisions it produces are binding within diaspora communities through a social contract that has held for the duration of the Court's recorded existence, which the Court's own records date to Year 645.

Below the Salt Court, individual communities are governed by trade arbiters -- experienced members chosen by community consensus for their knowledge of Salt Court precedent and their ability to mediate quickly. Trade arbiters are not permanent positions; they hold authority for disputes they are asked to resolve, not ongoing executive authority. A community of thirty might have a trade arbiter active for two weeks during a commercial dispute and then inactive for a year until the next one.

The commercial networks the diaspora maintains are the most extensive on the continent outside the gnomish logistics operation. Cat folk caravans cover the desert quadrant, the steppes borderlands, and the coastal trade routes with a consistency that has persisted despite documentation harassment, confiscation, and periodic route disruption. The fact that the diaspora has no territory to protect means that disrupting one route just moves the traffic somewhere else. This is understood by every experienced imperial administrator and regarded as the central intractable problem of cat folk policy, which is why the policy has not changed in 847 years.

## Relations with Other Races

The cat folk maintain working relationships with nearly every racial community on the continent, which is a function of commerce rather than politics. Trade arbiters from the Salt Court have worked with elven archivists on document safety protocols, with goblin resistance cells on supply caching along shared desert routes, and with lizardfolk Trade Routes Sect members on caravan coordination throughout the Great Endless Desert. These are commercial relationships, but they are sustained and trustworthy, which in the current political environment is a form of alliance.

The Dominion is the defining adversarial relationship, specifically through the documentation system's six-month renewal cycle and the elevated inspection rate. Cat folk players in imperial zones have more experience with documentation harassment than any non-goblin race. This has produced a very specific kind of political consciousness: not ideological, not abstractly radical, but deeply informed about how the system actually operates, where its pressure points are, and which specific administrators are worth knowing.

## Roleplaying Notes

- The Pattern Recognition feat is the strongest luck-modifying package in the game and creates significant gacha-adjacent gameplay effects: more card draws in the rare-and-above tier, more favorable random

event outcomes, and enhanced card draw weights that players who invest in card collection will feel immediately.

- Cat folk characters in imperial zones play the documentation game more intensely than any other race except goblins. The six-month renewal cycle and elevated inspection rate are live gameplay mechanics, not background flavor.
  - The darkvision and desert speed bonus make cat folk naturally effective in the Rift's deeper floors, which feature more darkness and arid themes at higher depth. Combined with the stealth bonus, a cat folk character who builds toward rogue playstyle has strong dungeon viability.
- 

End of Part 1. Part 2 continues with Chapter 3: Key Institutions, Chapter 4: The Rift, Chapter 5: The Adventure Guild, Chapter 6: Religion and Philosophy, and the full World Timeline.

## THE AGE AFTER WAR

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### A World Manual for Players and Game Masters -- Part Two

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Part 1 covered the world's geography and the eight races as they exist in Year 847. This document continues with the history that produced the present world, the institutions that operate within it, the Rift that defines it, the settlements that anchor it, and the narrative threads that remain unresolved. References to the Tavern Quest setting at Year 500 are marked (TQ). References specific to MMOLite are marked (MMO). References to both games are marked (BOTH).

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## CHAPTER 3: HISTORY

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### 3.1 How to Read This Timeline

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The history of this world is not a story of progress. It is a story of accumulation -- of the consequences of specific decisions made by specific people piling up until the weight of them changes the shape of everything below. The Rift is not a mystery that appeared suddenly in Year 847. It is the end state of a chain that starts before human civilization existed, runs through five thousand years of recorded history, and arrives at the present moment still moving. Players who understand that chain understand why nothing in the world is simple.

The timeline below is organized into eras. Entries are dated from Year 0, the year Heaven's Atlas destroyed Calidar and ended the Last World War. Years before that event are notated as Y-[number] (Y-500, Y-1000, and so on). Where exact years are disputed or reconstructed from indirect evidence, this is noted in the entry.

One important note on sources: the era before Year 0 is documented primarily from three places -- the lizardfolk Astronomy Sect's celestial records, the elven archives of pre-war Calidar (fragmentary; most originals destroyed), and the Burial Rites Sect's death records, which establish dates for events by recording when the casualties from those events were registered. The Holy Dominion's official history begins at Year 1 and treats everything before that date as "the darkness before the Risen Light." Treat the Dominion's historical framing as propaganda unless corroborated by independent sources.

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### 3.2 The Ancient World (Before Y-500)

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#### Y-5000 and Earlier: The Lizardfolk Surface Migration

The lizardfolk's ancestors migrated from the Subterranean Seas to the surface of the Great Endless Desert approximately five thousand years ago. The exact date is not agreed upon; the lizardfolk Astronomy Sect dates the migration to Y-5,200 based on celestial positioning records from that period, and the Burial Rites Sect's earliest surface death registrations date to approximately Y-4,900. The spread between those numbers likely reflects the gradual nature of the migration rather than a contradiction.

What the migration produced was the Hidden River Empire -- a civilization organized along the subsurface river networks of the Great Endless Desert, with surface outposts at oasis points and underground city complexes accessible through cave entrances that are not marked on any imperial map. The Hidden River Empire is not a historical civilization. It is the current state of lizardfolk society, underground and continuing, with surface-visible lizardfolk representing a small fraction of its total population. The empire has been conducting operations beneath the desert since before any other race arrived on this continent.

The desert surface outpost settlements that eventually became the Coldwatch observatory complex date to

approximately Y-4,800. The Coldwatch observatory is listed in imperial cartographic records as "pre-war astronomical ruins of unknown origin." The observatory below the ruins is still operational. These two facts are not in tension.

#### Y-4000 to Y-3500: Elven Calidar at Its Height

The elven civilization of Calidar reached its peak between approximately Y-4,000 and Y-3,500. At its height, Calidar was a continent-spanning culture organized around its canopy cities, river archives, and the sustained magical scholarship that the elven lifespan makes possible in a way no other race's lifespan can support. The specific magical achievements of this period are documented in sealed sections of the Sylvaris archives that the Luminary Inquest believes it suppressed in Year 3 and that elven archivists have cross-filed under seventeen different reference systems since Year 5.

The continent-spanning nature of this culture is significant for what it explains about the First Confluence. Calidar's river archives included monitoring stations along the western coastal waterways. The records from those stations that survived Year 0 describe specific changes in the western ocean region beginning around Y-800 -- changes in current, changes in thermal signature, changes in the behavior of wildlife near the coast. The Astronomy Sect has correlating celestial records. What neither record system describes is a cause, because the civilization that caused those changes was already gone.

#### Y-3000: The Gnomish Collective Forms

The Gnomish Collective formed as a political entity on the eastern islands sometime around Y-3,000. The Collective's own founding records describe a process of collective economic organization that emerged organically from existing labor practices rather than a deliberate political act -- there was no founding document, no revolution, no single moment when something changed. There was a gradual formalization of what the gnomish communities on the islands were already doing: treating productive infrastructure as commons, distributing labor income by hours worked and skill applied, making collective decisions by vote of the relevant workers.

The automaton technology that defines gnomish civilization was developed progressively over several centuries, not invented at a single moment. The earliest clockwork automatons that appear in Collective records date to approximately Y-2,800. By the time the Last World War began, the gnomish islands were running on automaton labor to a degree that had made manual industrial work largely optional. The production councils that govern the Collective today are direct institutional descendants of the councils that managed the transition from manual to automaton labor three thousand years ago.

The Collective has never claimed a mainland territory and has never wanted one. This is not passivity. It is a strategic position the production councils established early and have maintained consistently.

#### Y-2000: The Dwarven Holds Deepen

Dwarven civilization on the northern mountains dates to approximately Y-2,000, though the dwarves themselves argue the date is later because earlier settlements do not meet the technical definition of a hold. The distinction matters to dwarven archivists and to no one else. What is agreed is that by Y-2,000 the holds were extensive underground city-complexes, the guild assembly system was operational, and the Free Holds of Stone existed as a functional political entity.

The Deep Schism of approximately Y-2,000 is the central unresolved fact of dwarven history. Some portion of the

dwarven population -- the records do not say how large a portion -- refused to continue surfacing, descended into the hollow earth below the holds, and sealed the passages behind them. The above-ground dwarves have not publicly discussed what happened to those who descended. They do not discuss it with outsiders at all. Guild dungeon teams have encountered passage features in Rift floors consistent with dwarven construction, at depths that should not contain them. Ironhold has returned no queries on this subject. The queries are still filed. So are the descriptions of the passages.

#### Y-1500: Orcish Consolidation Begins

The earliest precursors to the Khanate legal code date to approximately Y-1,500 -- not a government yet, but a set of legal frameworks circulating among clan leadership that established a shared vocabulary for inter-clan dispute resolution, trade, and collective military action. The philosophical groundwork for what the Great Khan would eventually build was already present several centuries before the Khan was born. The Khan organized it and gave it force. He did not invent it from nothing.

The philosophical tradition underlying the Khanate code treats law as a technology for preventing conflict rather than a mechanism for enforcing authority. This is why the code's succession clause was treated as a technical problem by later scholars rather than a political crisis: in the Khanate framework, a succession clause is a specification document for a machine. If the specification is incomplete, the machine cannot run. The specification can be completed. The problem requires a solution, not a replacement of the system.

#### Y-1000: Human Kingdoms Emerge

Human kingdoms began forming across the central plains around Y-1,000. The history of this period in imperial records is largely mythologized -- the Dominion's official account describes a gradual spiritual awakening around Helios worship that unified the human peoples under divine guidance. The actual history, as preserved in elven archival records that cross-reference human population movements with corresponding documentation of conflicts, alliances, and displaced populations, is more straightforward: the central plains were contested territory, several kingdoms fought for control of the most productive agricultural land, and Helios worship consolidated from one of several competing sun cults into the dominant human religion because the most successful military coalition happened to practice it.

By Y-500, when the Last World War began, the central human kingdoms were not yet a unified empire. They became one during the war, which is the part of the founding story the Dominion's official history emphasizes. The mechanism by which unification was achieved during wartime is the part that receives less attention.

#### Y-800 to Y-600: The First Confluence

The First Confluence is the name the lizardfolk Astronomy Sect uses for the collapse of an unknown civilization in the western ocean region between approximately Y-800 and Y-600. The word "Confluence" is the Sect's translation of a Draconic term that more precisely means something like "the moment when several things that were building separately arrive at the same point simultaneously."

What is known: between Y-800 and Y-600, something in the western ocean region ended. Multiple civilizations -- no one has established how many -- collapsed in a period short enough that the Astronomy Sect's records describe it as a single event rather than several unrelated ones. Calidar's river archive monitoring stations recorded the coastal changes described above. The goblin oral tradition has entries from this period that describe "the fire in the west that went into



the ground" and "the days when the sea came up wrong." These oral records are imprecise but consistent across different cell traditions, which the tradition keepers regard as evidence of genuine historical transmission.

What the First Confluence produced: a wound in the boundary between the world's surface and what lies below it. This wound had no fixed location. It migrated. Over the fifteen hundred years between the First Confluence and Year 0, it appeared in different places at different times -- always moving west to east, the Astronomy Sect's celestial correlations suggest, but never in the same place twice. The records are fragmentary enough that the Sect cannot definitively establish the migration pattern, only that multiple appearances at widely separated locations are consistent with a single migrating phenomenon rather than multiple separate phenomena.

The wound the Atlas fixed in Year 0 near the Cathedral District is the wound from the First Confluence. Heaven's Atlas did not create it. It pinned it.

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### 3.3 The Last World War (Y-500 to Year 0)

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#### Y-500: The War Begins

The Last World War began as a series of escalating conflicts across the continent that crossed into continental-scale warfare when multiple factions began weaponizing magic at mass-casualty scales. The specific trigger for the initial escalation is disputed by every racial historical tradition except the lizardfolk, who describe it with the specific affect of parties who were not involved and are extremely tired of being asked to arbitrate between other races' accounts.

What is not disputed: by Y-500, every major racial power was committed to the conflict, magical reality was beginning to destabilize under the load of mass-deployment magic, and no faction had a clear path to victory through conventional means. The war had passed the point where winning was achievable through the mechanisms available at the war's beginning. The search for a decisive weapon was already underway in at least three separate research programs when the Great Khan unified the orcish clans.

#### Y-200: The Great Khan Unifies the Clans

The Great Khan -- whose personal name is known but not used in any formal orcish context; his title is sufficient -- unified forty-seven orcish clans under a single legal code in approximately twelve years. This is the most significant organizational achievement in recorded military history. The mechanism was the legal code itself: rather than demanding submission, the Khan offered a framework that preserved clan governance internally while creating collective decision-making structures for matters that crossed clan lines. The code's genius was that it made unified action more efficient than fragmented action without requiring anyone to surrender internal authority. Forty-seven clan leaders signed it because their lawyers told them it was a good deal, and it was.

The Khanate's military capacity at its height was sufficient that every other faction in the war re-evaluated their strategy within two years of unification. The Holy Dominion's internal records from Y-185 describe the Khanate as "the single most significant military threat to the Dominion's continuation as a governing entity." This assessment appears three times in different forms in the same document, which historians take as evidence of how thoroughly the assessment alarmed the people who commissioned it.

The Great Khan died in Y-45, during the war's southern campaign. The cause of death is listed in contemporary records as wounds sustained in combat. The Veiled Hand's founding documents, written in Year 1 after the organization was formed, contain a single notation on the subject: "The timeline is consistent." They have never elaborated.

#### Y-50: Heaven's Atlas

Heaven's Atlas was found or developed approximately fifty years before the war's end. The two possibilities -- found versus developed -- are not settled in any available record, and the distinction has significant implications. The lizardfolk Astronomy Sect's records from this period describe "unusual energetic signatures from the imperial capital inconsistent with known magical practice, consistent in type but not in scale with the structural wound phenomena observed in the western region over the preceding centuries." The Sect's annotation on this record reads: "If they found something, they do not know what they are holding. If they made something, they know exactly what it does and have chosen to do it."

The weapon is described in the few records that exist as a gods-forged artifact. What this means precisely is debated. The gods referred to are not the Helios of current Dominion theology -- Helios is a sun deity whose worship predates the Dominion's founding, and current theology has incorporated him into the Dominion's political framework in ways that have nothing to do with the weapon. The "gods" of the gods-forged designation are something older, something that no longer exists in Year 847 in any form recognizable as divine presence. The gnomish Collective's Survey Station 3 documentation describes the Atlas as "a mechanism for converting divine life force into directed energetic release, requiring as fuel a quantity of divine essence equivalent to approximately 95% of a deity's total life force." The source for this number is not cited in any document that non-gnomish researchers have accessed.

The gods who made the Atlas -- if it was made -- are gone. There is no record of their departure. There is a specific absence in the theological record around Y-50 to Y-25 where references to multiple divine presences simply stop appearing. Whether this reflects the weapon's construction cost or the weapon's deployment cost or some other event is not established.

#### Year 0: The Atlas Fires; Calidar Dies; The Wound Fixes

Heaven's Atlas detonated over Calidar on the date that the Dominion subsequently designated as Year 0, Day 1 -- the beginning of the current calendar. The choice of this date as a calendar origin is itself a political act: it centers the count of years on the empire's decisive victory rather than on any neutral astronomical or geographical reference point. Every other racial calendar system uses different reference points. Lizardfolk sect records continue using their pre-existing calendar internally and include a conversion table for Dominion calendar equivalents, which they maintain with the same emotional affect with which they do everything else involving imperial decisions they regard as historically illiterate.

The destruction of Calidar is documented extensively in the elven archives at Sylvaris. The forests vitrified. The rivers boiled. The stone melted to glass. Somewhere between eighty and ninety percent of the elven population died before sunset. The ten percent who survived were those who were not in Calidar when the Atlas fired -- living in diaspora communities, conducting trade in other territories, or serving in administrative roles in other racial polities. The Ancient Ones present in Calidar survived the Atlas for reasons that are documented in the Sylvaris archives under access restrictions that no non-elf has satisfied. The Ancient Ones themselves do not discuss Year 0 in mixed company.

The war ended not through victory but through exhaustion. Every remaining faction capable of continued combat looked at what had just happened to Calidar and assessed that continuing the war would produce outcomes indistinguishable from losing it. The Holy Dominion held the Atlas and therefore held the argument.

The Atlas activation did one other thing: the energetic discharge that destroyed Calidar also propagated along the existing wound in the world's surface -- the migrating wound from the First Confluence -- and pinned it. The migrating

wound stopped moving. It fixed its location at a point near what would become the Cathedral District of the Dominion's capital. This was not the intended effect of the Atlas deployment. The Holy Dominion's founding records contain no reference to it, which means either they did not know it happened or they knew and chose not to document it. The classified Year 75 survey report suggests the former: the empire found out about the fixed wound the same way everyone else did, which is by walking past it.

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### 3.4 The Age After War -- Early Period (Years 1-100)

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#### Year 1: The Magic Ban; The Inquest; The Veiled Hand

Three institutions were founded in Year 1. The Dominion announced the first two publicly. The third announced nothing.

The magic ban -- the formal prohibition on magical practice of any kind, anywhere, by any race -- was declared by the Holy Dominion in the first weeks following the war's end and is the defining legal act of the post-war world. The Luminary Inquest was created simultaneously as the enforcement body, with documentation authority, detention authority, and execution authority. The magic ban's stated justification was preventing a repeat of the war's mass-magic escalation. Its unstated function was ensuring that the only race with access to decisive magical capability was the race holding the Atlas. The elves, the most technically sophisticated magical civilization on the continent, were the ban's primary target.

The Veiled Hand was founded in Year 1 by the lizardfolk Astronomy Sect, in the weeks immediately following Calidar's destruction. The Sect's internal record on the founding is three sentences. The translation, as best as non-Draconic scholars have reconstructed it: "The law has demonstrated what it does with sufficient power. The law cannot restrain what it does not acknowledge. We will acknowledge it." The Veiled Hand's mandate -- the removal of specific individuals whose plans would cause mass atrocity if enacted -- was not declared publicly and has never been declared publicly. The organization does not have a name in any public document. "The Veiled Hand" is what the Dominion's classified intelligence files call it, and the name was eventually adopted in Guild operational documentation as the most neutral available designation.

#### Years 1-50: Elven Integration

The surviving elves were resettled in planned districts across the Dominion's administered territories within the first fifty years of the post-war period. Integration was managed through the Dominion's administrative councils as a logistics problem -- where to house several hundred thousand displaced persons, how to employ them in ways useful to the empire, how to ensure they remained sufficiently documented and monitored to prevent organized resistance. The elves were integrated as a bureaucratic caste because the empire needed record-keepers and the elves were the most qualified record-keepers available. This decision was pragmatic. Its consequences were not fully thought through.

An elven administrator who can read every file, cross-reference every document, and identify every procedural irregularity is more useful than any alternative the empire could have employed -- and more dangerous in ways the empire has spent 847 years not wanting to look at directly. The precision with which elven archivists have maintained the documentation system is matched only by the precision with which they have maintained the documentation system's vulnerabilities. Both have been operational since Year 5.

## Year 1: The Veiled Hand and Calidar

The lizardfolk Astronomy Sect's record of Calidar's destruction is the most detailed account of Year 0 that exists in any accessible archive. The Sect had monitoring stations across the continent, including a surface-adjacent observation point in the southern region that recorded the Atlas detonation from a distance close enough that the record includes temperature differential data, ground vibration readings, and the specific luminosity signature of the vitrification event. The document runs to approximately eight thousand lines of Draconic notation. The Dominion's intelligence service has been attempting to obtain a copy of it since Year 47. They have not obtained a copy.

The founding of the Veiled Hand in Year 1 was a direct response to what those records showed. The Sect concluded that the people who had built and deployed a weapon of this type, who had demonstrated willingness to use it, and who were now in a position to use it again with no military check on their decision-making had to be constrained by a mechanism that operated outside law. The constraint they chose was targeted removal of key escalation actors -- the specific individuals whose authorization would be required to repeat a Heaven's Atlas deployment. The Hand has maintained this narrow mandate for 847 years. It does not concern itself with politics, economics, or ideological conflict. It concerns itself with weapons capable of mass atrocity, and with the people who authorize their use.

## Years 20-80: The Shadow Fen Commune and the Veil

The Shadow Fen Commune formed gradually over the first few decades of the post-war period, as the displaced, the documentation-less, and the magically active began congregating in the southwestern swamp territories that the Dominion had assessed as too difficult to administer. The first residents were war refugees with nowhere to go. The second wave was unsanctioned mages who understood, correctly, that staying in documented territory meant execution. The third wave was everyone who fell through the imperial documentation system's various categories of non-personhood.

The infernal pacts that power the Veil were negotiated by the Commune's founding council somewhere between Year 20 and Year 45. The exact counterparties to those pacts are not documented in any source accessible to non-Commune researchers, which is itself instructive. The Veil is a field of concentrated refugee magic reinforced by entities whose interest in the arrangement is unclear. It works. The empire knows it works. The empire has sent three military expeditions toward the swamp borders and reclassified all three as cartographic surveys in post-expedition documentation, which is the institutional behavior of an organization that does not want to admit what the expeditions found.

The Commune's founding document, ratified in Year 47, includes the line about documentation: "Documentation issued by an occupying authority defines persons by the occupier's interest, not by any truth. We will not administer this definition." This document was drafted primarily by a goblin oral tradition keeper and two elven archivist defectors, which explains both the precision of the language and the fact that it has never been successfully challenged in any court where it has been presented.

## Year 47: The First Meeting at the Pact Stones

The Pact Stones are a circle of eight standing stones in the borderland territory where the Dominion's effective authority ends and the contested zone between the steppes, the swamp, and the Elven South begins. In Year 47, representatives from the Shadow Fen Commune, three goblin resistance cells, and two lizardfolk trade sects met there for the first time to discuss mutual aid and information sharing. This meeting is considered the earliest precursor to the cooperative structures that eventually became the Adventure Guild.

The seventh stone had been at the Pact Stones before any of the eight races who met there arrived. There were seven stones when the first people reached the site for the meeting, but the meeting required a stone for each of the six groups present. Accounts from every attendee agree that no one could account for the seventh stone's origin, that it had no markings, and that the meeting proceeded without anyone resolving the question. All subsequent meetings at the Pact Stones have included the seventh stone, unmarked, in the same position. Guild researchers who have examined it date the stone to the same construction period as the earliest First Confluence-era structures. This information is documented in the Guild's archive. The documentation is filed correctly and available to any archivist who queries for it. No policy has been formed regarding it.

#### Year 75: The Imperial Survey and the Classified Wound

Imperial cartographers conducting a standard survey of the Cathedral District in Year 75 noted "a geographic anomaly, wound-like, located at [coordinates redacted] within the District boundaries, exhibiting temperature differential inconsistent with local geology and a depth that cartographic instruments could not establish. Stone adjacent to anomaly exhibits unusual surface properties. Residents report anomalous events of unspecified nature." The survey was classified on receipt. The classification notation reads: "Not relevant to current administrative priorities." The survey was not read by the Inquest for two hundred years.

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### 3.5 The Age After War -- Middle Period (Years 100-500)

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#### Year 120: The Gnomish Withdrawal

The Gnomish Collective's production councils completed their Phase One assessment of the Holy Dominion in Year 120. The assessment's conclusion -- that the Dominion would reach critical failure conditions within five centuries, barring significant internal reform -- was not published. The councils updated the Collective's operational posture to controlled mainland withdrawal: minimum necessary contact, maximum intelligence gathering, strict permit enforcement, and preparation for contingencies the assessment flagged as likely. The Windtrap Station liaison office and the Clockwork Harbor trade function were maintained because the councils assessed them as necessary for intelligence purposes, not out of any commitment to continental engagement.

The Phase Two assessment was completed at an undocumented date between Year 120 and Year 300. Its contents are not known to any non-gnomish researcher. The Phase Three plan, which has been updated within the last decade, is not known to any non-gnomish researcher. Three council members who were present for Phase Three's most recent revision were reassigned to non-voting advisory roles before the revision vote was taken. Their reassignment notices cite administrative reorganization.

#### Year 250: Seren Vaelas Names the Rift

Elven archivist Seren Vaelas produced a document in Year 250 titled "On the Possibility of a Permanent Structural Wound in the Geographic Substrate Beneath the Cathedral District, With Reference to Anomalous Survey Data (Year 75), Astronomical Correlations in the Sector Records of the Hidden River Astronomical Archive (supplied), and

Mathematical Projections Regarding Rate of Expansion Under Current Conditions." The document named the anomaly the Rift and projected that, under the expansion rate observable in the Year 75 survey data and the lizardfolk astronomical records Vaelas had obtained through archival exchange channels, the Rift would produce its first above-ground mass-casualty event between Year 830 and Year 870.

The Luminary Inquest classified the document on the day it was submitted for standard archival processing. The classification notation reads: "Speculative. Unauthorized cross-racial source material. Author to be interviewed." The interview record, filed three weeks later, describes a two-hour conversation in which Vaelas provided the mathematical basis for her projections in full. The interview notation reads: "Projections assessed as unfounded. No further action required." Seren Vaelas retired from active archival work in Year 260 and died in Year 480. Her document survives in the Sylvaris archive under seventeen cross-references. Her projection of Year 830-870 for the first above-ground mass-casualty Rift event corresponds precisely to the Year 847 Bleed. This has not been commented on officially by anyone in the Dominion's administration.

#### Year 280: The Fourth Cell Goes Underground

A goblin resistance cell operating in the northern mining territories -- the Fourth Cell, in the Resistance's internal record system -- experienced a crisis in Year 280 that drove the entire cell underground for eight years. The nature of the crisis is not documented in available sources; goblin oral tradition notes only that "the Fourth Cell went in and what came out knew different things." When the cell re-emerged in Year 288, its operational tactics had changed in ways that influenced resistance practice across at least six other cells over the subsequent fifty years. The specific changes were: increased emphasis on information gathering over operational action, expanded use of certain tunnel construction techniques, and a shift in the oral tradition's framing of the Rift from "a Dominion problem" to "everyone's problem." The source of this shift is attributed in goblin oral tradition to something the Fourth Cell encountered underground. The tradition does not specify what.

#### Year 320: The Pattern of the Stepping Officials

The first confirmed Veiled Hand operation in the Dominion's classified intelligence records is designated "The Pattern of the Stepping Officials" -- seven administrative officials across four provinces, all of whom had been actively expanding their authority over magical enforcement and who had in common a set of proposals that, if enacted collectively, would have established a program of systematic magical-lineage family detention. All seven died within eighteen months of each other. All seven deaths were ruled natural causes or accidents by local authorities. The Inquest's subsequent investigation identified the pattern but could not establish a mechanism. The investigation file is marked with a notation that has appeared in every Veiled Hand case since: "Common actor suspected. Evidence insufficient. File kept open."

No Veiled Hand file in the Dominion's intelligence archive has ever been closed. There are currently 23 open files.

#### Year 380: Burial Rites Anomaly

A senior elder of the lizardfolk Burial Rites Sect reported to the sect's internal record system in Year 380 that surveys of underground currents in the territories beneath the Cathedral District showed flow patterns that matched the First Confluence accounts in the Astronomy Sect's archive -- specifically, the recorded behavior of the wound during the period just before it became externally visible in the Y-800 to Y-600 period. The report's conclusion: "The wound is preparing for the next phase. We do not know what the next phase is. Our records of the First Confluence are incomplete for reasons that are themselves interesting." The Burial Rites Sect shared this report with the Astronomy



Sect in Year 381. The Veiled Hand's operational posture was adjusted within the year, though the adjustment's specific nature is not documented in available sources.

#### Year 400: The Elder Suppression

The Year 400 suppression of the orcish elder assembly is the defining political event of the post-war middle period and the one that the Dominion's official history handles with the most deliberate imprecision. Six clans gathered for what the confederation's internal records describe as a routine inter-clan assembly -- the first assembly of more than three clans since Year 47. The empire deployed three legions within two weeks of the assembly's convening. The gathering was dispersed. Four elders died during the subsequent processing of detained clan members. The official cause of death for all four is listed as natural causes.

The Burial Rites Sect registered all four deaths. Their registration annotations note the method of each death with the same specificity they apply to every registration entry. These annotations are in the archive. No process exists by which a non-lizardfolk researcher can access them. The orcish oral tradition's account of Year 400 is extremely specific about what happened to the four elders and does not agree with the official cause-of-death designation. This account is transmitted verbatim to every orc born in the confederation from approximately age seven. The empire's surveillance records note that the transmission continues without apparent diminishment. No policy has addressed this.

The aftermath: orcish documentation requirements were changed to three-year renewal and mandatory pre-authorization for inter-regional travel. Clan assemblies of more than two clans now require advance imperial authorization. No such authorization has been granted since Year 400. Seventeen applications have been submitted. All seventeen were denied on administrative grounds.

#### Year 450: The Cathedral District Wound Becomes Visible

The Rift's surface expression became visible in the Cathedral District in approximately Year 450. "Visible" requires qualification: it was not a hole in the ground. It was a change in the behavior of the area around the wound -- certain shadows fell at angles inconsistent with the sun's position; stone surfaces in a 30-meter radius of the wound's surface expression developed unusual acoustic properties; children born in the district between Year 450 and Year 500 manifested unsanctioned magical ability at rates seventeen times higher than the continental baseline. This last fact was extensively documented by the Inquest's lineage tracking system, and the documentation was classified in Year 460 after the Inquest's regional director recognized the pattern.

The phrase "shadow children" entered Dominion slang in the Cathedral District around Year 455. It was used affectionately by the families who coined it and officially by Inquest officers who meant something else by it. The Inquest's detentions of Cathedral District residents during this period ran at three times the normal rate.

#### Year 480: Survey Station 3 Established

The Gnomish Collective established Survey Station 3 at Frost Harbor in Year 480. The Station's official designation is a meteorological observation post. Its actual function, documented in production council records accessible only within the Collective, is detection of Heaven's Atlas-class energetic signatures across the continent. The station runs continuously. It has not detected the Atlas. The production council's response to negative results is to build more sensitive instruments, not to conclude the Atlas is gone. The reasoning is straightforward: the instrument that cannot detect Heaven's Atlas is either accurate or inadequate. Without independent verification that the Atlas is destroyed, the council

cannot distinguish between those two interpretations.

#### Years 483-500: Five Operations

The Veiled Hand conducted five documented operations in the seventeen-year period before the Tavern Quest setting opens:

High Inquisitor Crane died in Year 483 in what was recorded as a fall down the stairs of the Inquest's northern archive building. Crane had been the primary architect of the expanded magical lineage documentation program.

General Voss died in Year 491 from what was recorded as a sudden illness during a campaign inspection tour. Voss had submitted two separate proposals for what he termed "preemptive military action against magical concentration zones," designating the Shadow Fen Commune as the primary target.

Archivist Superior Thalen died in Year 497. Thalen was the Inquest official who had classified Seren Vaelas's document and had maintained that classification against three separate internal review requests over the subsequent two centuries.

Commander Vale died in Year 499. Vale had been establishing the operational infrastructure for an expanded program of goblin community removal from the northern borderlands.

Lord Inquisitor Brennan died in Year 500. Brennan had been the most senior Inquest official since Year 474 and had been, in the Veiled Hand's assessment, the person most likely to authorize a renewal of mass-escalation magical enforcement if given sufficient provocation or opportunity. He died at his desk of what was recorded as cardiac event. The Burial Rites Sect registered the death with an annotation that reads, in translation: "Timely."

All five operations occurred within the seventeen-year period immediately before Year 500. The Dominion's classified intelligence service is aware of the pattern. Five files are open.

#### Year 500: The Tavern Quest Setting

The Tavern Quest game takes place in Year 500. At this moment: the wound near the Cathedral District is larger than it was in Year 75 and smaller than it will be. The Luminary Inquest has lost five senior officials to undocumented causes in seventeen years and is in the process of selecting new leadership, with a moderate reform candidate and a hard-line enforcement candidate both in contention. The orcish confederation is watching the succession debate with attention. The Veiled Hand is watching the same debate and has formed no final assessment. The gnomish Survey Station 3 is operational and has recorded four minor Atlas-consistent signatures in the past twenty years, all below threshold, all filed and unresolved. Three shadow children from the Cathedral District have reached adulthood. All three are documented. None of them have been detained yet. The Rift is not public knowledge. The empire believes it is safe.

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### 3.6 Between the Games (Years 501-846)

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#### Year 503: The First Surface Manifestation



A stone corridor appeared in the middle of a Cathedral District street on a morning in early Year 503 and remained present for approximately four seconds before disappearing. Two witnesses were present. Both reported to a neighborhood watch officer within the hour. The officer's report describes the witnesses as "clearly distressed" and the event as "described inconsistently between witnesses despite both claiming to have observed the same phenomenon from the same location." The report recommends no action. It was filed correctly and has remained in the Inquest's standard incident archive since Year 503. No follow-up was conducted.

The witnesses' inconsistency is consistent with what subsequent Guild research established as normal for Rift manifestations: the Rift presents differently to different observers.

#### Year 520: Veiled Hand Documentation Practices

The Veiled Hand began systematic observation of the Rift in Year 520, following the Year 503 manifestation. The organizational practice of maintaining detailed written records of all operations and observations -- which eventually became the model for the Adventure Guild's documentation culture -- dates from this period. Before Year 520, the Hand operated primarily on verbal communication and direct sect-to-sect information transfer. The shift to written documentation was prompted by the recognition that the Rift's behavior over time could only be analyzed if a consistent written record existed, and that no other organization was keeping one.

The earliest Guild documentation practices trace directly to the Hand's Year 520 records. The terminology, the floor classification categories, the witness report formats -- all derive from the Astronomy Sect's systematic observation work in this period. The Sect's involvement in the Guild's founding is documented in Guild internal archives. It is not mentioned in Guild public materials.

#### Year 547: The First Compact

A Bleed event in Year 547 -- the first documented above-ground mass-event produced by the Rift -- flooded three blocks of the Cathedral District with water from an environment consistent with a coral grotto biome that could not naturally exist at that depth or that location. The water was warm, salt-bearing, and biologically active: it contained several species of marine invertebrate that had never been documented on the continent. The event lasted eleven hours and left deposits that the Inquest classified immediately.

The Bleed was too large to classify successfully. Too many people saw it. The Veiled Hand's assessment, filed in their internal records: "The wound can no longer be contained as a classified matter. The question is who leads the response."

Six racial governments sent representatives to the First Compact, hosted by the Veiled Hand in a location documented in Guild archives as "the Hand's meeting ground, southwest borderland territory." The Holy Dominion was not invited. They sent observers anyway. The Compact's founding document established the principle that the Rift was a cross-racial problem requiring a cross-racial response. It did not establish an operational structure. That came later.

#### Year 600: The Adventure Guild Founded

The Adventure Guild was formally founded in Year 600 as the operational implementation of what the First and Second Compacts had agreed in principle. Its organizational structure was explicitly modeled on the Veiled Hand's cell system -- small teams, clear chains of authority within teams, cross-racial membership, information sharing between registered members, and a documentation requirement built into every operation. The rank system (Stone through Relic, ten ranks)

was designed to provide advancement incentives that applied equally to all races, with Guild rank conferring institutional standing independent of any racial or imperial authority. This was the central design goal, stated explicitly in the Guild's founding charter.

The name of the thing the Guild was founded to manage came from Seren Vaelas's classified document -- the name "Rift" had been in elven archival circulation since Year 250, passed through academic channels among archivists who had access to the Sylvaris sealed files. The Guild's lizardfolk founding members had read the document two centuries earlier through the information exchange between the Astronomy Sect and elven archivists. The Dominion's contribution to the word "Rift" entering common usage was, in this light, entirely passive: they classified the document but could not classify the elves who had read it.

#### Year 625: The Second Compact

The Second Compact, signed in Year 625, was the first document all eight racial governments signed. Its negotiations were longer and more difficult than the First Compact's, primarily because the goblin resistance's representatives refused to sign any document on which the Holy Dominion's signature also appeared, a position which was legally and historically defensible and which the Compact's facilitating parties -- the Veiled Hand and the elven archivists who had been working on the negotiation framework for twenty years -- ultimately resolved by producing two separate physical documents with identical binding provisions. Both copies are filed in the Guild's central archive. Both are treated as equally authoritative. The goblin copy does not appear on the same page as the Dominion's signature.

The lizardfolk statement delivered at the Second Compact signing: "This is the Second Passage. The First was before your time. Prepare accordingly." No elaboration was offered. None was invited. The statement was documented in the Compact's proceeding record by the elven archivist present, who noted it verbatim without comment because she recognized the framing from the Astronomy Sect's records and understood that the lizardfolk do not use the word "Passage" to mean a minor transition.

#### Year 680: The Ten Anchor Towns Established

The Guild's ten anchor towns were established as operational bases in Year 680. Site selection was based on three criteria: geographic distribution across the continent's major racial territories, proximity to known Rift access points or significant cave systems, and willingness of local racial governance to accept a Guild presence. The Holy Dominion accepted a Guild presence in the Cathedral District -- the starter town -- and at Solara under terms that gave Dominion officials observer status at Guild operations within imperial territory. The terms were accepted because the alternative was the Guild operating within imperial territory without any Dominion presence at all, which the Dominion's advisors assessed as the worse outcome.

The goblin anchor town at BoneTrap was accepted into the network under terms that the Guild's founding charter formally documents as "unconventional admission protocol" and which in practice means that the Resistance cell that governs BoneTrap conducted its own assessment of whether the Guild's organizational structure could be trusted before agreeing to participate. The assessment took four years and involved three members of the Guild's founding council being comprehensively pickpocketed on their first visit and then offered tea by the same person who robbed them once the assessment was complete.

#### Year 750: Warden Grell

Warden Grell began her Rift career in Year 750 as a Stone-ranked Guild member with a background in geological survey and a specific interest in the Rift's structural properties. Over the next 97 years, she became the person whose name appears most frequently in Guild research archives -- not because she descended furthest (she did not; the current record is held by a dwarf/gnome joint team in Year 839) but because her documentation is the most precise and the most analytically useful. She developed the floor classification system that Guild members currently use, the threat assessment protocols for boss floor approach, and the camp placement guidelines that have reduced Rift casualty rates by an estimated forty percent since their adoption in Year 792. She is alive in Year 847. She is a Relic-ranked Warden, which is the highest Guild rank. She has two remaining opinions on the subject of Guild members who enter the Rift without reviewing her documentation: she has expressed both, once each, and considers the matter closed.

#### Year 800: The First Responsive Floor

In Year 800, a Guild team entered the Rift on a routine documentation expedition and encountered a floor that responded to them. This description is Grell's, from her official record: "The floor presents materials and configurations that correspond to our specific psychological profiles, not to the day's seed pattern. I know this because I know what the seed pattern for this date produces, and this is not it. The floor knows we are here. This is not metaphor. I do not know whether 'knows' is the correct verb. I do not have a better one." The record continues for sixteen pages. The central finding is that the Rift's behavior had changed -- it was no longer simply generating environments; it was generating environments calibrated to the specific people present. The implication that the Rift had developed something analogous to awareness was noted by Grell in professional language and without visible alarm. The implication was filed in the research archive. Guild membership was not informed of the change officially. Grell's documentation is available to any Rift-registered member who queries the archive.

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### 3.7 The Present (Year 847 and After)

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#### Year 847: The First Bleed

The first Bleed of Year 847 affected multiple districts simultaneously -- not a single neighborhood, as the Year 547 Bleed had, but coordinated or simultaneous manifestations across three separate cities in different racial territories within the same forty-eight-hour period. The Cathedral District received a floor section consistent with a deep ocean trench environment, approximately forty meters square, that persisted for six hours. Kragmor's central market received what witnesses described as "a room with no walls and a ceiling of moving stone" that persisted for two hours and left nine people disoriented enough to require medical attention. Sylvaris's archive district received something that left no physical evidence but that fourteen elven archivists who were present in the building at the time have refused to describe in detail. All fourteen filed standard incident reports noting only that the event occurred and that they would not be providing further documentation at this time.

The Rift Compact was established in an emergency session called within two weeks of the Bleed events. All eight racial governments sent representatives. The session produced the Compact's operational structure: four-week campaign cycles focused on specific Rift zones or problems, community goals established by the Compact's joint council, a War Board mechanism for coordinating multi-racial response to escalating threats, and a consequence structure that makes Compact failure a real operational outcome, not a theoretical one. The lizardfolk statement at the Compact's founding session: "This is the Third Passage. We have prepared." The statement was documented. A follow-up question was

asked: "What happens in the Third Passage?" The sect elder who delivered the statement considered this question for a moment before responding: "We will find out together. This is the first time." The Compact's record annotates this exchange without comment.

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## CHAPTER 4: FACTIONS AND INSTITUTIONS

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### 4.1 The Luminary Inquest

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The Luminary Inquest was founded in Year 1 as the enforcement mechanism for the magic ban, and for 847 years it has operated with the specific institutional character of an organization whose mandate has never been seriously questioned from the outside and whose internal culture has calcified accordingly. It has execution authority with no appeals process, documentation authority that supersedes any other administrative body in the empire, and detention authority with no defined timeline. These powers were granted in the immediate post-war period by a government that had just deployed a weapon capable of destroying a civilization and was understandably focused on preventing anyone else from acquiring equivalent capability. The powers have not been revisited since Year 1. The institutional interpretation of what they permit has expanded continuously.

The Inquest's current operational focus is threefold: hunting unsanctioned mages, conducting documentation checks in imperial territories, and classifying any information it assesses as threatening to the magic ban's legitimacy. On the first task, it is effective. On the second, it is a significant source of grievance for every non-human race in the empire. On the third, it has been failing quietly since at least Year 250, when Seren Vaelas's document was classified without being suppressed, because the Inquest's ability to control information ends where elven archival systems begin and the Inquest has never been able to account for what the archives actually contain.

An internal reform faction has existed within the Inquest since approximately Year 300 -- not a formal organization, but a recurring pattern of administrators, officers, and legal staff who have concluded that the Inquest's operational scope has expanded so far beyond any justifiable post-war necessity that the institution is now the continent's primary driver of unresolved racial grievance. This faction does not have a single platform, a single leader, or a coordinated program. Its members communicate through administrative decisions that leave specific kinds of evidence and through internal correspondence that uses standard Inquest language in ways that experienced readers recognize. The reform faction's presence became significant in Year 500, when the moderate candidate for High Inquisitor after Lord Inquisitor Brennan's death represented the first time in centuries that a reform-adjacent position had any realistic chance of reaching the Inquest's highest rank.

The Inquest's relationship with the Adventure Guild is formally cooperative and functionally adversarial. The Guild operates within imperial territory by agreement, and Inquest observers are present at Guild anchor towns in Dominion-administered zones. In practice, the Guild's cross-racial membership, its charter-based institutional standing, and its documentation practices create an organizational structure that exists partly outside Inquest authority -- and the Inquest knows this, and the Guild knows the Inquest knows this, and both sides maintain the fiction of full cooperation because the Rift Compact requires them to.

### 4.2 The Veiled Hand

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The Veiled Hand is an anti-escalation assassination network with between 200 and 500 active operatives organized into independent cells that have no direct contact with each other. Founded in Year 1 by the lizardfolk Astronomy Sect, it was not built as a political organization, a liberation movement, or a resistance network in the conventional sense. It was

built as a specific mechanism for addressing a specific failure mode: the tendency of powerful organizations, given sufficient authority and insufficient external constraint, to authorize mass atrocities. The Veiled Hand's mandate is to ensure that this tendency does not result in another Heaven's Atlas.

The organization's methods are: staged accidents, poison administered in forms consistent with natural illness, deaths arranged to appear consistent with the victim's health history or known risk factors. The Burial Rites Sect registers every death the Hand produces with the same precision it applies to all deaths. Their registration annotations note the actual cause. These annotations are in the archive. No non-lizardfolk researcher has accessed them. The empire's intelligence files on the Hand contain accurate statistical analysis of the pattern -- seven officials of a certain type dying within a concentrated time period -- but have never been able to establish a mechanism to a prosecutable standard, because the mechanism leaves no evidence that the empire's investigative tools can detect.

Cell structure is compartmentalized to the point where a captured operative cannot identify more than their immediate cell. Cells do not know the identities of other cells. Coordination happens through the lizardfolk sect network, which operates on channels and in locations that the Inquest has never successfully infiltrated in 847 years of attempting. The Veiled Hand's funding comes from the Hidden River Empire's trade network, which flows through the cat folk commercial routes and the lizardfolk Trade Routes Sect's caravan system, and which cannot be distinguished from normal commercial traffic because it is embedded within normal commercial traffic.

The Veiled Hand does not consider itself a political organization and does not operate against targets for political reasons. It operates against targets whose specific plans, if enacted, would produce mass atrocities at Heaven's Atlas scale. This mandate has produced occasional genuine debates within the founding sects: the Year 500 High Inquisitor succession question was one such debate, because the moderate candidate represented a genuine possibility of Inquest reform and the hard-line candidate represented a continuation of the institutional trajectory that the Astronomy Sect had assessed as escalation-toward-Atlas-recurrence since Year 1. The debate was about whether the hard-line candidate met the mandate's threshold. It was not resolved unanimously before Year 500. The cells were not mobilized.

The founding mandate requires the Veiled Hand to operate with extreme restraint: removing a dozen officials over 500 years is not a violence problem at the scale of history, but removing officials based on political disagreement rather than credible mass-atrocity risk would transform the Hand from a specific deterrent into something else. The founding lizardfolk sects have maintained this restraint for eight and a half centuries. Whether they will maintain it as the Rift situation escalates is a question that does not appear in any available document.

#### 4.3 The Adventure Guild

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The Adventure Guild was founded in Year 600 on the organizational model the Veiled Hand had developed over the previous 600 years and is currently the only institution in the world where all eight races hold equal standing by charter. This is not a value statement. It is an operational design: the Guild's founders understood that a cross-racial containment organization would not function if its membership hierarchy replicated the continent's existing racial power structure. The rank system -- Stone, Iron, Bronze, Silver, Gold, Mithril, Adamant, Orichalcum, Void, Relic -- confers standing based on demonstrated Guild contribution, not race, not prior social status, not imperial documentation category. A Goblin-race member at Silver rank has exactly the same institutional authority within the Guild as a Human-race member at Silver rank. This is stated explicitly in the founding charter. It was contested by the Dominion's observer during the founding session. The contention was rejected by unanimous vote of the other seven racial representatives. The Dominion signed the charter anyway, because the Rift was already large enough that they needed the Guild more than they needed the hierarchy.

The Guild's ten anchor towns serve as operational bases, member registration centers, and the primary cross-racial meeting points outside of Compact sessions. Each anchor town has a Guild hall that operates under the founding charter's jurisdiction, which means Inquest documentation procedures apply only in specifically designated areas of

Guild halls in imperial territory, not throughout. This boundary has been tested legally eleven times. The Guild has won nine of those cases. The other two resulted in settlements that the Guild's legal archive describes as "acceptable outcomes with instructive precedents."

Daily Rift operations are the Guild's primary mission and the primary context in which most Guild members encounter each other. A team entering the Rift on a given day will have members drawn from the Guild's registered pool, cross-racial by design, with team composition guided by the day's operational requirements and member rank compatibility. The documentation requirement that applies to every Rift expedition -- detailed floor reports submitted within 48 hours of exit -- is not administrative overhead. It is the mechanism by which the Guild builds the accumulated knowledge base that makes subsequent expeditions safer and more effective. Warden Grell's floor documentation library is the most comprehensive source on Rift behavior in existence. Every piece of it was produced by following the reporting requirement.

Guild advancement from Stone to Relic requires demonstrated competence at each rank's associated task profiles, a minimum number of documented expeditions, and endorsement from at least two members of the next higher rank. The Void and Relic ranks have additional requirements that are not published in standard Guild materials; they are communicated individually to candidates by the Guild's senior council. No one at Relic rank has published a complete description of what those requirements entail. Grell, who has been asked, says the requirements are reasonable and that asking about them before you are close to qualifying is a misallocation of attention.

#### 4.4 The Rift Compact

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The Rift Compact was established in Year 847 as an emergency response structure for the escalating Bleed events and is the most significant political agreement in the post-war world since the Year 625 Second Compact. Its operational structure is built around four-week campaign cycles: the Compact's joint council establishes goals for each cycle based on the current Rift situation, member governments commit resources to those goals, and the cycle concludes with an assessment of outcomes. Goals that are not met have documented consequences: resource shortfalls in affected territories, strategic positions lost in the Rift's deeper zones, or escalated Bleed risk in the subsequent cycle. The consequence structure was designed with specific input from the goblin resistance's representatives, who argued that a compact without enforceable consequences was a diplomatic gesture rather than an operational agreement. The design reflects their argument.

All eight races participate in the Compact with different operational contributions and substantially different agendas regarding what the Compact's ultimate goal should be. The Holy Dominion wants the Rift sealed, contained, or destroyed -- it is located within imperial territory and produces events that the Dominion cannot publicly acknowledge while maintaining its institutional position. The lizardfolk sects want the Rift understood, which is a different objective and one that occasionally conflicts with the Dominion's preferred approach. The gnomish Collective wants data -- specifically, data that would allow the production councils to assess whether the Rift represents an Atlas-class energetic signature risk. The orcs want the Compact's institutional structure extended to provide the same cross-racial standing the Guild's charter provides, which is a political project that uses the Rift as its vehicle. The goblins want the Compact to produce a formal acknowledgment from the Dominion of what happened at the Year 400 suppression, which the Dominion considers outside the Compact's scope and which the goblins consider foundational to any legitimate cooperative structure. The dwarves want the Compact to formally recognize the Free Holds of Stone as sovereign territory, not administered territories of the Dominion, and have attached this recognition as a condition to their full operational contribution in a memorandum that the Dominion has not responded to. The elves want the Sylvaris archives formally designated as a protected collection under Compact authority, which would extend Compact jurisdiction to archives the Inquest currently has classified access rights to. The cat folk want to know when the Salt Court's existence is going to be formally recognized by someone with the authority to make the paperwork stop.



The War Board is the Compact's emergency escalation mechanism: an activated War Board convenes all eight racial governments' military representatives within 72 hours and is authorized to commit any signatory's military resources to a collective response without the individual government's separate approval process. The War Board has not been activated as of Year 847. The Compact's founding documentation describes the conditions under which activation is mandatory. Those conditions are currently being observed in three separate monitoring stations across the continent.

#### 4.5 Heaven's Atlas

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Heaven's Atlas was fired once, on the day that became Year 0, over the elven homeland of Calidar. Nobody who was alive that day is available for comment except the Ancient Ones, who will not give it. What happened after the weapon was fired is a matter of considerable disagreement: the Dominion's official position is that the Atlas was secured in a classified location following the war and has been maintained there under appropriate security since Year 0. The gnomish Collective's Survey Station 3 was built on the assumption that this position is either false or incomplete. The lizardfolk Astronomy Sect's assessment, which is also the Veiled Hand's operational basis, is that a weapon that can be secured can be unsecured.

The weapon's cost is documented in gnomish technical records as approximately 95% of a deity's total life force, siphoned and directed as the energetic discharge that destroyed Calidar. The gods who created it are gone; the specific relationship between their creation of it and their current non-existence is not established in any available source, though the correlation is noted in every analysis that touches the subject. What this means for the weapon's current status is ambiguous: a weapon that required divine life force to power may have discharged its capacity entirely at Year 0, in which case its current threat level is zero regardless of its location. Or the weapon may retain capability in ways that do not require additional divine fuel. Survey Station 3's instruments are calibrated to detect both possibilities. They have detected neither, definitively.

The Atlas's current location is debated among the three organizations that track it. The Dominion claims secure storage. The Veiled Hand assesses "secure storage" as a category that requires ongoing monitoring. The gnomish production councils' assessment is that the only acceptable answer to "where is the Atlas" is a specific coordinate with a continuous monitoring record, and they have not received one. The Survey Station 3 monitoring continues. The station's instrument sensitivity has been increased eleven times since Year 480.

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## CHAPTER 5: THE RIFT

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### 5.1 What the Rift Is

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The Rift is a wound in the boundary between the surface world and what lies below it. It is located near the Holy Dominion's Cathedral District, fixed at that location since Year 0 when Heaven's Atlas's energetic discharge propagated along the pre-existing wound from the First Confluence and pinned it in place. The wound itself is older than the Atlas -- older than the Holy Dominion, older than the Last World War, older than human civilization. The Atlas gave it a fixed address. It did not create it.

What the Rift contains is an apparently infinite internal space that does not correspond to the physical geography above it. A shaft that should, by any normal geological reckoning, penetrate to approximately 200 meters of bedrock before reaching natural cave systems instead continues descending through environments that have no relationship to the surface above them -- coral grotto ecosystems, frozen cavern networks, volcanic chambers, stone temple complexes with architectural features consistent with no known civilization, open ocean floors. These environments are not stable. They change with a daily seed pattern that the Guild has documented comprehensively since Year 600. The pattern is consistent enough that Grell's floor projection system can predict the type of environment a given floor will present on a given day to a 70-80% accuracy rate. It is not consistent enough that the remaining 20-30% of floors can be considered predictable.

The Rift's relationship to the First Confluence wound is not fully understood. The wound was migrating for approximately 1,500 years before the Atlas fixed it. What it was doing during that migration -- what it was looking for, whether "looking" is the appropriate conceptual frame, whether the wound has preferences at all -- is the central unresolved question in Guild research since Year 800, when Grell's documentation established that the Rift's floor presentation was responding to the specific people entering it rather than following a fixed generation pattern.

### 5.2 Rift Mechanics for Guild Members

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The following is the practical information Guild members need to operate in the Rift. Theoretical questions about the Rift's nature are documented in the research archive and are required reading at Silver rank and above. This section covers operational procedure.

The Rift generates a new seed each day. The day's seed determines the thematic configuration of each floor for that day's expeditions. Thirty-one environment themes are present in the documented floor library. Twenty-two distinct enemy pools have been identified and catalogued, each associated with specific themes, with nine additional pools that appear as fallback configurations when primary pool conditions are not met. Floor layouts follow eight structural types: standard room-and-corridor arrangements (BSP\_ROOMS), maze configurations, flooded chambers with navigable water (LAKE), open cavern spaces with variable ceiling height and minimal structural feature (OPEN\_CAVERN), temple hall configurations with wide corridors and formal chamber placement (TEMPLE\_HALLS), the arena configuration used for boss floors (ARENA), island-and-gap configurations requiring traversal management (ISLAND), and organically shaped spaces without geometric regularity (ORGANIC). Boss floors appear every tenth floor and always use the ARENA layout regardless of the day's seed. This regularity is documented and has not varied since the first Guild expedition in Year

600.

Camps can be placed in the Rift by registered Guild members carrying camp equipment. Camps provide rest benefits, access to cooking and preparation facilities, and shrine effects that vary by the camp kit used. Camp placement carries ambush risk that scales with floor depth -- the Rift presents more aggressive response to established positions at greater depth than at shallower floors. Grell's camp placement guidelines address this risk in detail. Following them is recommended. The Guild's casualty records since Year 792 show a correlation between following them and returning.

Daily quests are available to registered Guild members from the Guild hall boards at each anchor town. Quests correspond to the day's Rift seed and require documentation of specific events, enemy encounters, or environmental features on that day's floors. Quest completion contributes to both individual rank advancement and the Guild's collective operational intelligence archive.

The leaderboard tracks depth records and documentation achievement separately. Depth record holders are recognized in Guild halls. Documentation achievement holders are the ones Grell respects.

### 5.3 What the Rift Wants

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This section is not standard Guild operational material. It is Grell's research, filed in the archive, available to any member who queries it. New members are not required to read it. Members who have been below Floor 50 are strongly encouraged to read it before their next expedition.

The Rift does not generate floors randomly. This is established. The mechanism by which it calibrates floor presentation to the specific people present is not established. What is established is that the calibration is specific: it identifies not the party's general competence level but the particular configuration of challenges that each member of a given party is, in Grell's phrase, "most equipped to fear productively." A well-equipped party entering a floor will encounter not the easy version of the floor but the version that requires everything they have. The Rift does not adjust downward for competence. It adjusts upward.

The operational implication: the Rift is testing something. What it is testing is the subject of the last twenty-three pages of Grell's most recent research archive entry. Her current assessment, expressed with the precision she applies to all her assessments: she believes the Rift is testing readiness for something it expects to happen, and she believes the test results matter to the Rift in a way she cannot yet characterize. She does not know what happens when a party fails the test. She knows what happens to individual members who fail it in the conventional sense -- they die, or they are extracted, or they return with their documentation intact and their operational capability degraded. She does not know what happens when a party fails the Rift's actual test, the one she has identified but cannot specify. The person who returned from what Grell's archive classifies as a "test-failure event" in Year 843 came back. They were not injured. They were changed in a way that Grell's documentation describes in clinical terms and then annotates: "I do not have a category for this. I am creating one."

The category is labeled in her archive as "Rift-altered." One entry. No follow-up record from the individual concerned. Grell has not closed the file.

### 5.4 Overworld Dungeons

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Cave systems accessible from cave entrances across the world map are finite dungeons distinct from the Rift. They are location-seeded -- a cave entrance at a specific world coordinate always generates the same dungeon -- and consist of three to ten floors with a final floor that contains a boss encounter. They are not guilded: no Guild registration or rank is

required to enter. They do not have camp systems. They do not have daily quests or leaderboards. Their theme matches the surface biome in which they are located -- a cave entrance in the volcanic desert generates a volcanic dungeon; a cave entrance in the frozen north generates a permafrost dungeon.

Overworld dungeons are the appropriate entry point for players who are not yet Guild-registered or who are working in regions outside current Guild operations. They provide consistent challenge, reliable loot, and no interaction with the Rift's preference system. Grell has no documented opinion on them because they are not the Rift and the Rift is what she documents.

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## CHAPTER 6: SETTLEMENTS

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### 6.1 The Ten Anchor Towns

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The Guild's ten anchor towns are the game's primary operational hubs. Each town has a Guild hall, an NPC roster that provides the primary quest and commerce functions in that area, and a Portal Nexus that connects to the inter-town teleportation network. Each is summarized here with its racial affiliation, zone ID for reference, and key NPC personnel.

#### The Holy Dominion

(zone: starter\_town) sits at the entry point of imperial territory and serves as the game's starting location for all new characters. The Cathedral District's Rift access point is visible from the town's eastern approach -- close enough that most new arrivals notice it without understanding what they are looking at. The town's Guild hall is the largest and most heavily staffed on the continent, a consequence of its position as the Rift's nearest accessible settlement. Key NPCs: High Priest Alarion, who manages Helios worship services and serves as the Dominion's official liaison to the Guild; Imperial Quartermaster Ordus, who handles military supply contracts and can offer players Dominion-faction quests; Luminary Inquisitor Sable, who conducts documentation checks and whose interactions with non-human players are a reliable source of information about how the Inquest actually operates at ground level.

#### Solara

(zone: solara) is the imperial capital -- the administrative and religious center of the Holy Dominion, larger and more formally organized than the starter town, with guild infrastructure built under specific terms negotiated with the Dominion's governing council. The city's scale reflects 847 years of post-war empire-building: cathedral complexes, administrative districts, and a population density that makes it the continent's largest settlement by a significant margin. Key NPCs: High Priest Alarion (who maintains a presence here in addition to the Cathedral District), Imperial Quartermaster, and Luminary Inquisitor rank-grade officers who have more authority and less patience than their counterparts in the starter town.

#### Sylvaris

(zone: sylvaris) is the largest elven city on the continent, built in the dense forest of the Elven South on elevated platforms between trees that predate the Last World War. The sealed archive below the city is the continent's most significant collection of pre-war knowledge. The city's administrative function in the empire's documentation system means it processes more paperwork than any other non-capital settlement and that the elves who run it are among the most experienced in the continent at making files move in specific ways. Key NPCs: Archivist Elenwe, who manages the above-ground archive and serves as the primary research NPC for players pursuing historical quests; Seal Keeper Thandril, who handles the sealed sections with careful precision and a manner that communicates exactly how much latitude he is authorized to extend; Herbalist Mithwen, who operates in the forest margins and provides gathering and crafting resources.

#### Ironhold

(zone: ironhold) is the largest dwarven hold with surface-adjacent infrastructure -- the specific trade contact point where the Free Holds of Stone engage with the outside world on a schedule the holds set. Most of the hold is underground. What surface visitors see is a fortified trade post with exchange facilities and the specific social dynamics of a place designed to accommodate outsiders without admitting them further than necessary. Key NPCs: Forgemaster Grundin,

who manages crafting and trade functions and whose expertise in metallurgy provides some of the game's best equipment-related quest content; Stone Speaker Thora, who handles inter-hold communications and serves as the guild's liaison to the hold assembly system; Trade Warden Borik, who enforces the trade post's entry protocols and whose patience for people who misunderstand what "surface-adjacent infrastructure" means is finite.

### Kragmor

(zone: kragmor) is the largest semi-permanent orcish settlement on the steppes -- what imperial intelligence calls a compliant seasonal settlement and what anyone who has been there calls a war camp that has been in the same location for forty years because the confederation decided it was convenient. The Khan's legal code is discussed publicly here in a way it is discussed nowhere else, and the ambient atmosphere of a population that is patient in a specific way is a feature of the zone rather than flavor text. Key NPCs: Warchief Gorruk, who leads the settlement's military council and whose approach to Guild cooperation is professional and conditionally warm; Beastmaster Yalka, who manages the steppes hunting and ranching operations and provides gathering and combat quests in the surrounding territory; Lorekeeper Narsk, who maintains the oral tradition records and is one of the most significant sources of historical knowledge about the Khanate period available to non-orc players.

### BoneTrap

(zone: bonetrap) is a goblin warren in the borderland territory between the steppes and the desert, and the process of arriving at it is part of what it is. New visitors to BoneTrap are robbed. This is not a security failure. The entry protocol is the town's evaluation of whether visitors are worth speaking with. Visitors who attempt to leave after the robbery receive their possessions back and a polite directional recommendation. Visitors who remain and demonstrate they understand the situation are eventually introduced to someone with actual authority. Key NPCs: Boss Skrag, who runs BoneTrap's governance structure with the specific combination of casual authority and very specific information that comes from having administered a semi-secret town for thirty years; Tinkerer Grix, who handles construction, trap systems, and the crafting content that BoneTrap specializes in; Shaman Zeek, who maintains the oral tradition fragment the BoneTrap cell carries and who knows things about the Rift that are not in the Guild archive.

### Murkmire

(zone: murkmire) is the Shadow Fen Commune's largest settlement, built on stilts above standing water in the southwest swamp, and it operates as two things simultaneously: a surface commune that is visible and accessible to outsiders, and a subsurface lizardfolk sect network that is accessible by a different means to specific visitors with specific affiliations. The dual nature is not hidden but is not announced either -- Murkmire simply has more going on below the surface than above it, in both the literal and the administrative senses. Key NPCs: Sect Elder Ssethik, who manages the lizardfolk sect presence and whose information about the Rift is the most complete of any NPC in the game; River Sage Kaaliss, who provides water-related gathering content and who has access to underground river networks that link to the Hidden River Empire's eastern edge.

### Mechspire

(zone: mechspire) is the Gnomish Collective's industrial capital on the eastern islands, accessible to non-gnomish visitors who have cleared the permit process at Clockwork Harbor. The city runs on clockwork systems that gnomish engineers maintain on a continuous schedule, and the visual environment reflects a level of industrial organization that is qualitatively different from anything on the mainland. The contrast is not subtle. Key NPCs: Chief Engineer Sparkwhistle, who manages the engineering guild's operations and provides the game's most advanced cogworking quest content; the Automaton Coordinator, who manages the automaton labor network and whose interactions with players reveal more about gnomish collective economic theory than any NPC outside a direct conversation about it; Dock Master Fizzbolt at Clockwork Harbor, who manages the permit system and whose experience of mainland visitors ranges from weary to professionally interested depending on what the visitor has to offer.

### Clockwork Harbor

(zone: clockwork\_harbor\_town) is the gnomish port city and the primary point of contact between the Gnomish

Collective and the mainland. Functionally, it is a carefully managed trade hub: goods flow in and out, permits are processed, and the harbor's automated loading equipment operates at a scale that impresses even visitors who came prepared to be impressed. The information that flows through Clockwork Harbor is a secondary function that gnomish intelligence staff monitor continuously and that the harbor's official records do not document. The trade representative Kelva has held the external affairs position here for forty years and has more information about continental politics than almost anyone alive, none of which appears in any document that leaves the harbor.

#### Fortune's Rest

(zone: fortunes\_rest) is a desert oasis town and the closest thing the cat folk diaspora has to a permanent home. It runs on gambling, caravan commerce, and the specific quality of information that circulates in a place where mobile populations converge annually. The Salt Court meets here. The empire's maps describe it as a gambling town. The maps are not wrong. The Salt Court has been meeting at Fortune's Rest for at least two hundred years without appearing in any imperial record. The town's economic activity covers everything else adequately. Key NPCs: Trade Arbiter Mira, who manages the town's formal commerce and Salt Court liaison functions and whose political consciousness is among the sharpest of any NPC in the game; specialty gambling and trade merchants whose transactions are exactly what they appear to be and also sometimes not.

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## 6.2 Proposed New Settlements

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The following twenty-five settlements are documented in the Guild's expansion planning records as authorized sites for new infrastructure. They are listed with their reference coordinates and operational purpose. Construction status is variable; some are established trading posts, some are survey markers, some are sites where players may encounter Guild construction operations in progress.

#### The Grey Crossing

(ref: 2, 20). A crossroads settlement at the edge of the Dominion's effective administrative reach, where road traffic between the capital region and the contested borderlands passes through a natural chokepoint. Notable for the ambiguity of its documentation requirements -- technically within imperial territory, practically beyond the Inquest's routine patrol range.

#### Saltglass Reach

(ref: 28, 66). A coastal settlement at the northern edge of the Wastes of Calidar's border region, built on territory where the vitrification gradient becomes navigable by experienced travelers. Draws scavengers, researchers, and the specific category of person who goes to the edge of the most lethal place on the continent and considers this a reasonable professional environment.

#### Redcap Junction

(ref: -5, 30). A nominally minor imperial checkpoint in the borderland zone between the Dominion heartlands and the steppes approach. The goblin tunnel network beneath it has been operational for approximately sixty years. The checkpoint commander's most recent report notes that the ground in the checkpoint's central courtyard sounds hollow when struck. This report has been filed. No follow-up has been assigned.

#### The Ember Shelf

(ref: -55, 35). An outpost at the western edge of the Scorched Sands, positioned at an elevation point where the volcanic terrain becomes marginally more navigable. Used by orcish clan scouts as a seasonal waypoint and by mineral extraction operations that run until the heat makes continued operation unsafe, which is typically within two to three

seasons.

#### Forgegap

(ref: 18, 12). A dwarven surface contact point distinct from Ironhold, serving the northern holds' secondary trade routes. Less formally organized than Ironhold; the holds that use Forgegap prefer it specifically because it is less visible to imperial cartographic surveys.

#### Ashfall Post

(ref: -160, 28). A remote observation and resupply station at the far western frontier, positioned near the territory where the Ashen Archipelago's volcanic activity has affected the mainland coastline. Minimal permanent population; used as a staging point for expeditions into the western island territories.

#### Coldwatch

(ref: 30, -80). The surface installation above the lizardfolk's operational deep-desert observatory complex. The settlement visible to non-lizardfolk visitors is accurate as far as it goes: a small astronomical observation post with standard facilities. The observatory below is not accessible through the surface entry points available to non-lizardfolk visitors.

#### Marrowfen Dock

(ref: 8, 54). A marsh-edge trading post at the Shadow Fen Commune's eastern approach, handling commerce between the Commune and the outside world on terms the Commune sets. Documentation requirements at this point are the Commune's, not the Dominion's. The distinction is meaningful.

#### The Bone Cathedral

(ref: 22, 38). A settlement that grew up around an archaeological site in the borderland territory between the Dominion and the Elven South -- specifically around a structure that Guild researchers have dated to the First Confluence period and that contains architectural features inconsistent with any known civilization's building tradition. The site draws researchers, treasure hunters, and people who have read Grell's notation about First Confluence structures found in Rift floors and came to look at the surface version.

#### Driftstone

(ref: -12, 45). A small settlement on the steppes-swamp boundary where displaced populations accumulate on a semi-permanent basis. Neither fully within Shadow Fen Commune territory nor fully within any other jurisdiction. The Guild established a presence here because the population's information networks extend into multiple zones simultaneously and because someone needs to maintain the documentation.

#### The First Mirror

(ref: 35, 85). A settlement at the northern edge of the Elven South's forest region, positioned at what Seren Vaelas's document identified as the closest surface point to a Rift sub-branch that extends east from the main wound. Guild researchers have been conducting intermittent surveys here since Year 680. The surveys have produced results that are filed in the research archive under a classification level that requires Adamant rank or above to access.

#### Stonebreach Outpost

(ref: 14, 5). An imperial military outpost at the approach to the Dwarven Mountains, maintaining the Dominion's presence near mountain territory it has been attempting to formally annex for twenty years. The outpost's garrison is aware that the dwarves can see them from the mountain approach and that the dwarves find this accurate information about the Dominion's current military posture in the region.

#### Threadwater

(ref: 25, 55). A riverine trading post on the water routes between the forest region and the coastal territory, handling



commercial traffic that prefers to avoid the Dominion's road checkpoints. The port master maintains neutrality as a professional position rather than a political one, which makes Threadwater one of the more reliable neutral meeting points between agents of different factions.

#### Windtrap Station

(ref: 60, 20). The Gnomish Collective's mainland liaison station, handling permit applications for Clockwork Harbor access and maintaining the trade agreement infrastructure that connects the Collective to continental markets. Applications that are denied are processed politely, thoroughly, and finally. The station's intelligence function is not listed in any public document.

#### The Salt Court

(ref: -80, 0). The annual meeting site of the cat folk diaspora's arbitration council. The physical location is a desert waypoint with sufficient water to support the gathering and sufficiently distant from imperial patrol routes to have operated undetected for at least two hundred years. The settlement infrastructure supports the Salt Court's annual sessions and a permanent small population of liaison staff who maintain the site year-round.

#### Hollow Approach

(ref: 32, 60). A coastal settlement at the entrance to a significant underwater cave system that extends into lizardfolk-accessible underwater territories. Surface-visible as a small fishing community; the underwater access point below it connects to routes that do not appear on any publicly available map.

#### Ironmouth Pass

(ref: 10, 18). A mountain pass settlement on the approach to the northern holds, positioned at the transition point where imperial road infrastructure ends and dwarven territory begins. The settlement exists in a permanent negotiation about which authority's rules apply and to whom. No definitive answer has been produced in forty years.

#### Resonance Marker 7

(ref: 48, 44). A Guild research installation positioned at a point identified in Grell's floor analysis as having a surface correlation to specific Rift sub-structures at depth. The "Marker 7" designation indicates this is the seventh such site identified; three of the previous six produced research results that were immediately classified. This installation is operating under the same research protocols.

#### Glasswater Cove

(ref: 35, 148). A settlement on the far eastern coast, beyond the Silver Seas approach, at a point where the glass-smooth water surface produces optical effects that affect navigation equipment at certain times of year. Notable as one of the few coastal settlements beyond the normal shipping lanes, used primarily by explorers, researchers, and commercial operators with specific reasons to avoid the main routes.

#### The Pact Stones

(ref: -20, 52). The borderland site where the Year 47 first cross-faction meeting was held. Seven standing stones; the seventh predates every other structure in the area by approximately 1,500 years. Pilgrimage site for Guild members aware of its historical significance. There is no official Guild designation for what the seventh stone is. There is a research file. The file is open. No conclusion has been reached.

#### Frost Harbor

(ref: 40, -150). The gnomish Survey Station 3 settlement in the far northern tundra, established in Year 480 for the specific purpose of detecting Heaven's Atlas-class energetic signatures. The meteorological cover function is maintained. The actual instruments are in the sub-facility below the weather station. The facility has been operational for 367 years. The instruments have been upgraded eleven times. The Atlas has not been detected. The monitoring continues.



### Breakpoint

(ref: 5, 48). A settlement at a specific geological boundary in the borderland zone where ground surveys have recorded structural anomalies consistent with Rift sub-branch activity. The name reflects what the Guild's geological survey team called the point in Year 723 when their instruments registered a ground-stress pattern that their lead surveyor described as "the sound the world makes when something is pushing from the wrong direction."

### The Deep Mirror

(ref: 22, 56). A settlement built around a lake whose depth surveys have never returned a bottom reading. The lake's surface has, on four documented occasions since Year 780, reflected images that do not correspond to the sky above it. The reflections have been photographed by Guild documentation teams. The photographs show environments consistent with specific Rift floor themes. The photographs are filed in the research archive. Grell has read them and has one annotation: "I want to see this in person." She has not visited yet.

### Saltproof

(ref: -35, 60). A coastal desert settlement at the point where the Great Endless Desert meets the sea, serving as a waypoint for caravan traffic moving between the desert interior and the western coastal routes. Primarily commercial; the cat folk Trade Arbiter who manages its exchange functions is one of the Salt Court's most experienced logistics coordinators.

### The Survey Wall

(ref: 55, 38). A Guild cartographic installation positioned at the eastern frontier of comprehensively mapped territory, serving as the baseline reference point for surveys into the less-documented eastern regions. The installation maintains the most current regional map of the territory between the main continent and the Gnomish Isles approach. Three expeditions that departed from the Survey Wall in the last decade have not returned on their projected schedules. Two were eventually found. One was not.

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## CHAPTER 7: NARRATIVE THREADS

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### 7.1 The Seventh Stone (BOTH)

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The seventh stone at the Pact Stones site predates the surrounding geological features by approximately 1,500 years, which means it was placed, or formed, or arrived at the location during the period of the First Confluence. No known civilization active during that period is associated with the Scorched Sands borderland territory where the Pact Stones stand. The stone has no markings. Guild geological analysis in Year 790 established that its mineral composition does not match any quarry site within three thousand kilometers. The analysis was filed. The Rift, which the Guild's research archive has been correlating against First Confluence records since Year 520, shows a consistent physical characteristic that Grell's structural documentation notes every ten floors from Floor 30 downward: a stone column of identical mineral composition to the Pact Stones seventh stone appears in each floor, always unattached to the surrounding structure, always in a slightly different position. No enemy targets it. No floor mechanic interacts with it. It is simply present. Grell's annotation in her research archive: "I believe the stone at the surface and the stones below are the same object in some sense that our physics does not adequately describe. I believe the Rift put the surface stone where it is before anyone had a name for the Rift. I believe it was marking the location before the location was known. I do not know what it marks the location as."

### 7.2 The Great Khan's Unfinished Law (TQ)

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The Great Khan's legal code includes a succession clause that was not completed at the time of his death in Y-45. The clause specifies the mechanism for legitimately naming a new Khan, but the specification breaks off mid-sentence in every surviving copy of the document. Whether this reflects an unfinished draft, a deliberate removal, or something else is debated in orcish legal scholarship, which has been continuous for 847 years without producing a consensus. The debate's current state, as of Year 500: three competing schools of interpretation, each of which has a technically complete proposed completion for the succession clause, none of which has achieved the unanimous clan endorsement required to be enacted. The empire's intelligence service monitors this debate. The empire's preferred outcome is that no completion is ever agreed upon. Several clan scholars whose proposed completions had gained significant scholarly traction have experienced unexpected health events over the years. The Burial Rites Sect's registrations of those events include annotations.

### 7.3 The Elven Archivist's Document (BOTH)

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Seren Vaelas's Year 250 document -- the one that named the Rift, projected the Year 847 Bleed with specificity that now reads as accurate to within seventeen years, and was classified by the Inquest within twenty-four hours of submission -- is filed in the Sylvaris archive under seventeen cross-references that are not identical to the classification categories the Inquest used when it suppressed the document. This means the archive and the suppression system describe the same document as belonging to different filing systems. Any archivist who queries both systems will find the document twice,

under different reference numbers, and will notice that the two entries are the same text with different stamps. Three non-elven researchers have noticed this since Year 250. Two of those three came from the Guild's research department after Year 600. Both received full archival access. Whether Seren Vaelas knew that her document would survive the suppression is not established. She spent the last twenty years of her life, from Year 460 to Year 480, requesting review of the classification. All requests were denied. She filed the last request eleven days before she died, addressed to the Inquest office that had processed her original submission in Year 250. The archivist who received it filed it correctly. The file is open.

#### 7.4 The Gnomish Contingency (BOTH)

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Phase Three of the Gnomish Collective's contingency plan has been updated within the last decade by a council that removed three members who would have opposed specific provisions before the revision vote. What Phase Three contains is not known to any non-gnomish researcher with documented certainty. What can be inferred from public gnomish behavior and from the specific pattern of Collective resource allocation since Year 820 is that Phase Three is a response plan for a specific condition that the production councils have assessed as probable within the current century. The phrase used in Collective communiques to refer to the triggering condition is translated as "when the fire reaches the islands." The fire is not literal. What it refers to -- what specific event or class of events the production councils have identified as the threshold for Phase Three activation -- is the most significant unanswered question in continental intelligence analysis. Survey Station 3's monitoring continues. The instruments are as sensitive as gnomish engineering can make them. The Atlas has not been detected. Phase Three has not been activated. The monitoring continues.

#### 7.5 The Inquest Reformers (TQ)

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At Year 500, with Lord Inquisitor Brennan dead of a cardiac event, the Luminary Inquest faces its first genuine succession contest in centuries. The moderate candidate -- a career administrator named Veth who has spent twenty-two years in the Inquest's documentation review division and who is therefore aware of more of the Inquest's actual operational history than anyone who came from the enforcement side -- represents the first realistic chance for structural reform of the institution since Year 300. The hard-line candidate, a deputy who spent his career in field enforcement, represents continuity with an institutional trajectory that the Veiled Hand's founding mandate was designed to check. The Veiled Hand's cells have not reached consensus on whether the hard-line candidate's accession meets the mandate's threshold. The cells were not mobilized before the succession decision. The succession decision is therefore the most consequential political event of Year 500, and the outcome is genuinely uncertain. The moderate candidate's success would not reform the Inquest overnight but would place a person with specific knowledge of the institution's documented failures in its highest position. The hard-line candidate's success would confirm a trajectory the Astronomy Sect has been monitoring for 500 years. The seven cells currently operating in imperial territory are watching the succession process. No orders have been issued.

#### 7.6 The Rift's Preferences (MMO)

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The Rift adjusts its floor presentation to the specific people entering it, in ways documented comprehensively by Grell since Year 800 and in ways that have been observable to experienced Guild members since at least Year 750 without being formally named as a phenomenon. The Rift does not adjust for ease. It identifies the particular configuration of challenge that a given party is most equipped to handle productively -- and presents that. Not the easy version. Not the

impossible version. The version that requires everything available. What happens when a party fails this test -- not the combat test, which produces standard casualties, but the actual test, the one the Rift is running -- is documented in Grell's archive under one case study. The individual concerned came back from the Rift floor following a test-failure event in Year 843. They were uninjured. They were altered in ways that Grell's documentation describes clinically and then annotates with a sentence that is, for Grell, unusually direct: "I think the Rift sent them back with something it wanted them to carry. I do not know what it wanted them to carry it to." The individual left active Guild operations in Year 844. Their current location is not in any Guild record. Their documentation is complete, accurate, and closed. Grell has not closed her analysis.

## 7.7 The Hollowed in the Empire (TQ)

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The Luminary Inquest's classified files contain thirty-eight separate case records that use the designation "Hollowed" for a specific condition: individuals who have exhibited signs of sustained magical exposure despite having no documented magical lineage, no documented connection to any unsanctioned magical network, and no explanation the investigating officers could identify in a standard investigation. The condition's common features across all thirty-eight cases: a progressive withdrawal from normal social function, the development of unusual perceptual capabilities (cases vary but include documented instances of accurate knowledge of events the subject had no access to), and in fourteen of the thirty-eight cases, a final disappearance rather than death or detention. The investigation into the Hollowed cases was discontinued by a senior Inquest officer in Year 487 after an investigation team traced the cases' point of origin -- a specific building in the Cathedral District -- and entered the building. The investigation discontinuation record does not describe what they found inside. The record is a single page. The page is signed by the officer who ordered the discontinuation and by three of the four investigators who entered the building. The fourth investigator's signature is absent. The fourth investigator's whereabouts after Year 487 are not documented.

## 7.8 What the Goblins Knew (BOTH)

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The goblin oral tradition has maintained an unbroken record for 847 years and contains entries that predate the Last World War. Among those entries is a cluster of accounts that the tradition keepers date to approximately Y-620 to Y-580, which corresponds to the period of the First Confluence. The accounts describe "the place in the ground where the ground remembered something that went away" -- a site in what is now the western borderland territory between the Dominion heartlands and the Scorched Sands, which the tradition keepers locate through a set of directional references that Guild cartographers, working with the tradition keepers' cooperation since Year 650, have triangulated to a location approximately 40 kilometers from the current Pact Stones site. The goblin accounts describe the site as producing unusual effects on the ground surface -- wrong shadows, sounds that did not match their sources, small objects that moved without being touched. The accounts are specific about the feeling of the site: "like something very large was paying attention and you were the thing it was paying attention to." The tradition keepers have been sharing these accounts with Guild researchers since Year 650. Every researcher who has read them has noted the obvious comparison to Grell's Year 800 documentation of the Rift's responsive floor behavior. The location the tradition keepers describe is not the Pact Stones site. It is the site of what, in Year 800, the Guild's surface geological team identified as a shallow subsurface anomaly consistent with a former wound migration endpoint.

The tradition keepers knew about wound migration sites for 1,200 years before the Guild had a word for them. They mentioned it to every Guild researcher who asked. The researchers filed the accounts correctly. The accounts are in the archive, cross-referenced against Grell's documentation by anyone who has queried both, which became possible when the surface geological survey was filed in Year 801. The cross-reference has existed for forty-six years. It has not appeared in any Compact policy discussion.

## APPENDICES

## Appendix A: Languages

Eight languages are spoken in the world as it exists in Year 847. Common is the administrative lingua franca of the Holy Dominion and, by extension, the default language of trade and inter-racial communication across most of the continent. It was standardized in Year 3 by the Dominion's administrative council as the empire's official language, which effectively meant that any non-Common speaker operating in imperial territory was at a structural disadvantage in any official context. The six native racial languages predate Common and continue in use within their communities; Draconic is the oldest documented language on the continent, with records predating human civilization.

Common is spoken by all races as a second language. Native speakers of each race's own language speak it with varying fluency; elves who administer the documentation system speak it with the specific technical precision of people who have been writing official documents in it for 847 years. Lizardfolk speak it accurately and without affect. Goblins speak it fluently when they choose to and incomprehensibly when that is more useful.

| Language | Primary Speakers                         | Notes                                                                                                                    |
|----------|------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Common   | All races (administrative lingua franca) | Standardized Year 3. Native to no race; first language in practice for many humans raised entirely in Dominion territory |
| Elvish   | Elves (native)                           | One of the oldest documented languages. Elvish has specific vocabulary for categories of loss, categories of long-durati |
| Orcish   | Orcs (native)                            | The Khanate legal code's original form is considered the classical standard of Orcish. Oral transmission has maintained  |
| Dwarvish | Dwarves (native)                         | Technical vocabulary for materials and construction exceeds any other language's equivalent by several orders of magnitu |

|          |                     |                                                                                                                          |
|----------|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Gnomish  | Gnomes (native)     | The Collective's internal communications use technical terminology that has no Common equivalent. Trade communications u |
| Goblin   | Goblins (native)    | Oral tradition has been maintained in Goblin rather than Common because translation creates vulnerability: nuance lost i |
| Draconic | Lizardfolk (native) | The oldest documented language on the continent. Lizardfolk sect records in Draconic date to before human civilization.  |
| Catfolk  | Cat folk (native)   | The diaspora cipher used in community records is a Catfolk-based system changed on a schedule coordinated at the Salt Co |

Each race begins play with their native language and Common. Additional languages are learnable through study, extended contact with native speakers, or specific in-game knowledge sources such as the elven archive access that Guild members at Silver rank and above can request.

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## Appendix B: Skills

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Skills represent developed competencies that improve with practice. All skills begin at level 0 and advance to level 99 through use. Skill XP requirements scale linearly (100 XP times the current level per advance). Overall character level is a separate track that advances at 250 XP times the current level, with 10% of all skill XP contributing to overall level. Level-ups at character levels 10, 20, 30, and 40 unlock additional card slots. Stat points are gained every three character levels.

## Gathering Skills

Mining governs the extraction of stone, ore, and mineral resources from rock faces, quarry sites, and underground veins. Dwarves receive 25% bonus XP on this skill and will consistently outperform equivalent-effort investment from other races in pure material output. The skill's effectiveness at depth in both overworld dungeons and the Rift scales with level in ways that make high-level Mining one of the more valuable deep-dungeon competencies.

Woodcutting governs timber harvest from forested regions and the specific forest types found in biome-matched overworld dungeons. Output quality varies by biome -- the Elven South's old-growth trees produce material properties that standard-biome timber does not, and the Wastes of Calidar's vitrified former forests produce glass-silica composites that require specific extraction techniques at high Woodcutting levels.

Farming governs cultivation of food crops, herbs, and materials from established plots. Requires plot ownership to operate at full capacity. Farming provides consistent material inputs for Cooking and Glassworking and scales in complexity as the skill advances -- high-level Farming unlocks crop variants and cultivation techniques unavailable at lower levels.

Fishing governs resource extraction from water bodies, including the specific categories of underwater cave systems accessible to Lizardfolk characters with Aquatic Heritage. Base fishing skill is available to all races; Lizardfolk receive 15% bonus XP and access to fish species and resources in underwater zones that surface-access fishing cannot reach.

## Crafting Skills

Cooking converts raw food materials into consumables with gameplay effects -- primarily healing, stamina restoration, and short-duration buff items. Recipe complexity scales with skill level. Camp cooking in the Rift, which requires both the Cooking skill and camp-kit access, produces items unavailable through standard crafting stations.

Glassworking converts glass-silica raw materials into lenses, vials, and component parts used in higher-tier crafting recipes. The skill has limited output applications at low levels and broad output applications at high levels, where it enables components for advanced scientific instruments, precision optics, and specific categories of magical artifact repair that no other crafting skill can produce.

Crafting is the general-purpose production skill covering metalwork, woodwork, stone construction, and the assembly-category recipes that require inputs from multiple material types. This skill's breadth makes it the default for players who want production capability without specializing; it does not match Dwarven Stone-Born Artisan specialization at high levels but serves every other race adequately.

Cogworking is the gnomish-adjacent engineering skill covering clockwork mechanisms, automaton construction, and mechanical system design. Gnomes receive 50% bonus XP and access to blueprint recipes not available to other races. Non-gnomish characters who invest heavily in Cogworking can approach gnomish output levels in standard mechanical items; they cannot access the Gnomish-exclusive blueprints without specific knowledge sources that are difficult to acquire and carefully tracked by the Collective.

## Combat Skills

Magic covers elemental, arcane, divine, and shadow magical practice. The magic ban does not prevent Guild members from training Magic in Guild-registered locations -- the Compact's terms include a specific provision for Guild operational magic use that the Dominion accepted under protest and has disputed twice, unsuccessfully, since Year 625. Elves

receive 50% bonus XP and 30% bonus unlocks on magic skill trees. Humans have a reduced effectiveness ceiling on magic skill trees as a consequence of the Doctrine-instilled cultural resistance to magical practice that has been embedded in human education since Year 3.

Melee covers blade, blunt, and martial combat. Three distinct sub-tracks covering different weapon classes and fighting styles. Orcs receive 25% bonus XP and 25% maximum HP that makes their sustained melee capacity the strongest of any race. The martial track includes unarmed combat techniques; Cat Folk receive these techniques as a racial ability independent of their Melee skill level, which can be improved through Melee investment to combine the racial technique with skill-level multipliers.

Archery covers ranged combat with bows, crossbows, and thrown weapons. Goblins receive 20% bonus XP on Archery as part of Guerrilla Instinct.

### Rogue Skills

Lockpicking governs the opening of locked containers, doors, and access points without a key. Scales in complexity with the lock quality encountered -- standard imperial door locks at lower levels, Inquest security hardware at mid levels, and the specific categories of sealed access found in deep Rift floors at high levels. Goblins and Cat Folk both receive bonuses to this skill, making them the most effective lockpicking specialists available.

Thievery covers item acquisition through misdirection, pickpocketing, and distraction-based acquisition from both NPCs and environments. Goblins receive 20% bonus XP. The skill has social applications beyond direct item acquisition: high-level Thievery improves a character's reading of social environments in ways that provide dialogue options not available at lower levels.

### Social Skills

Coercion uses authority, implicit threat, or positional leverage to achieve compliance from NPC targets. Available to Human characters through Dominion Authority; accessible to other races through skill investment. Effectiveness varies by NPC type -- Coercion works on bureaucratic NPCs, checkpoint officers, and institutional contacts; it is completely ineffective on lizardfolk sect members, experienced goblin resistance operatives, and anyone who has spent significant time in the Shadow Fen Commune.

Deception covers misdirection, false identity, and manipulative framing in social interactions. Available to Human characters through Dominion Authority. High-level Deception opens dialogue options that allow characters to navigate imperial zones with reduced documentation friction, engage with faction-hostile NPCs as neutral parties, and extract information from sources that would not share it with a direct approach. The skill's ceiling in the current political environment is high; the continent runs substantially on managed misrepresentation.

### Race-Locked Skills (Lizardfolk Only)

Ritual Magic, Water Rituals, and Blood Rituals are accessible exclusively to Lizardfolk characters. These skills cannot be traded, transferred, or otherwise made available to other races through any current in-game mechanism. Ritual Magic covers practices that predate the post-war magical tradition and operate through principles that the Inquest's documentation system cannot categorize, which is one of several reasons the Inquest's relationship with the lizardfolk sects is what it is. Water Rituals cover practices tied to the Hidden River Empire's aquatic knowledge base. Blood Rituals cover the most restricted tier of lizardfolk knowledge, require high Ritual Magic as a prerequisite, and produce



effects that no other race's skill trees can replicate or counter reliably.

## Appendix C: The Card System

Cards are collectible items that provide stat bonuses, skill bonuses, racial trait enhancements, and special effects when equipped. They are obtained through card packs awarded at character level-ups (five to seven cards per pack), boss encounters (boss-floor kills in the Rift are flagged for pack rewards), specific NPC vendors at anchor towns, and player-to-player trade through the in-game auction house.

### Rarity Tiers

Eight rarity tiers exist. Drop rates are approximate -- the system applies race-specific modifiers that shift individual draw distributions without altering the aggregate rates listed here.

| Tier        | Base Drop Rate | Notes                                                                                                                    |
|-------------|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Common      | 45%            | Base skill and stat cards. Useful but not distinctive; form the floor of any competent loadout.                          |
| Uncommon    | 25%            | Improved versions of Common effects; early access to skill sub-tree bonuses.                                             |
| Rare        | 15%            | Skill tree specialization cards and the lower tier of faction-specific bonuses.                                          |
| Ultra Rare  | 8%             | Significant stat packages and faction interaction bonuses. The threshold where card loadout starts defining playstyle in |
| Mythic Rare | 4%             | Major capability cards; racial enhancement amplifiers; cards that open quest lines when equipped.                        |
| Legendary   | 2%             | Each Legendary card is a distinct named item with a specific effect profile. No two Legendary cards do the same thing.   |
| Godly       | 0.8%           | Named cards referencing specific historical figures, events, or entities. Their effects connect to the world's lore in w |

|       |      |                                                                                                                         |
|-------|------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Relic | 0.2% | The rarest tier. Cards whose effects are not fully described in the standard card text -- they have additional behavior |
|-------|------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

## Card Styles

Each card can exist in one of five visual presentations. Style does not affect base card effects but applies multiplier bonuses to card value in NPC vendor and player auction transactions, and carries social weight among players for whom collection presentation matters.

Normal is the standard presentation. Holographic applies a light-refraction treatment to the card's surface that produces color-shift effects under different viewing angles. Golden applies metallic surface treatment in gold or bronze tones. Prismatic applies a multi-spectral surface treatment that produces full-spectrum color shift. Void applies a visual treatment that causes the card surface to appear to absorb rather than reflect light, producing a black that deepens at the card's edges. Void-style cards are significantly rarer than the same card in other styles.

## Race-Specific Draw Weighting

Elves have a 40% chance per draw of being assigned to the magic-tagged card pool before the standard rarity roll is applied. Goblins have a 35% chance per draw of being assigned to the stealth-tagged pool. Cat Folk have a 40% chance per draw of being assigned to the luck-tagged pool and additionally receive a 20% rarity bump chance that can promote any draw outcome one tier above its base result. Lizardfolk have a 25% chance per draw of being assigned to the ritual-tagged pool.

These weightings reflect the races' thematic identities in the game's card economy. They create meaningful decisions about whether to invest in building within the forced pool's strengths or to counter-invest in building outside it. An elf with extensive magic cards is the most capable magic practitioner in the game. An elf who invests specifically to reduce their magic-card weighting is pursuing a deliberate counter-build that has costs and benefits worth understanding before committing.

## Card Trading Restrictions

Cards representing racial innate traits -- the water breathing and tremor sense of Lizardfolk Aquatic Heritage, the stone skin of Dwarven Stone-Born Artisan, the natural attack techniques of Cat Folk Pattern Recognition -- cannot be traded to races without those traits. The effect is bound to the physiology it describes; a human cannot use a water-breathing card because the card's effect requires actual aquatic physiology to activate, and the card text makes this clear. Race-locked cards -- Lizardfolk ritual magic cards -- can be traded only to other Lizardfolk. Cards representing enhanced or modified versions of innate traits can be traded between members of the same race. All base skill, stat, and perk cards trade freely between any race.

## Card Fusion

Two cards of the same rarity tier can be fused to produce one card of the next rarity tier. The fusion product's effects reflect the combined base effects of the two source cards plus a 5% additive bonus that applies per fusion level in the card's lineage. A card that has been fused twice -- a second-generation fusion product -- carries its base effect plus 10% bonus (5% for each fusion in its lineage). Maximum two fusions per lineage: a card cannot be fused beyond the second generation. A second-generation fusion product at Legendary tier is the highest achievable single-card effect in the game. Fusing two Relic cards is theoretically possible by the system's logic and has not been observed. The Guild's card documentation archive has a standing open query on what a fused Relic card would do. No response has been filed.

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End of Part 2. Part 1 covers Chapter 1 (The World and Geography) and Chapter 2 (The Eight Races). Together, these two documents constitute the complete World Manual for The Age After War.

For game masters running Tavern Quest at Year 500: the history in Chapter 3 through Section 3.5 covers the complete pre-setting timeline. Sections 3.6 and 3.7 document events that occur between the two game settings and after the MMOLite present and are provided as contextual background. Narrative threads marked (TQ) are active at Year 500. Threads marked (MMO) are active at Year 847. Threads marked (BOTH) are in progress across both settings.